

Video Shelf

User Guide

Version 1.18 | For Windows 10 and Windows 11

Contents

1. Welcome
What Video Shelf does, and what you need

2. Getting started
Installing, ffmpeg, and adding your first folder

3. A tour of the main window
Menus, Home, drives, the activity panel and the status bar

4. Finding folders
The filter bar, filters, views and ready-made lists

5. Working with scenes
Playing, previewing, rating, filtering and saved views

6. Working with many at once
Picking scenes or folders, and what you can do to them together

7. Keeping your collection up to date
Import, Refresh, Downloads and checking new files

8. Organising your collection
Details, covers, trimming, categories and the Collection Editor

9. Exploring your collection
Performers, studios, tags, Find by face and the Dashboard

10. Keeping things tidy
Collection Health, duplicates, comparing folders, Clean Up and screenshots

11. Keeping your data safe
Safety copies, moving your data, backups and copying to a drive

12. Settings
Display, Tools, Categories, Attributes, Covers, Faces, Storage and Privacy

13. Help and reference
What's New, the activity log, updates, shortcuts and troubleshooting

1. Welcome

Video Shelf keeps track of the video files you store across your hard drives. It builds a catalogue of every folder and scene, so you can browse, search, rate and play your whole collection from one place.

The catalogue lives on your PC, which means you can still browse everything when a drive isn't connected. You'll only need the drive when you want to play or change a file.

What you can do

- **Browse** folders and scenes as picture tiles, and preview a scene by moving the mouse across it.
- **Find** anything with search, filters and saved views.
- **Organise** with ratings, tags, your own categories and details, and covers chosen for you.
- **Explore** your collection through the Performers and Studios windows and the Dashboard.
- **Tidy up** by finding duplicates, comparing look-alike folders, and clearing out what you no longer want.
- **Protect** your catalogue with safety copies on another drive, and an optional PIN.

What you need

Item	Requirement
Operating system	Windows 10 version 1809 or later, or Windows 11 (64-bit)
Disk space	About 500 MB for the app, plus room for your catalogue and screenshots
Video player	Scenes open in your Windows default video player

You also need **ffmpeg**, a free program that reads your videos and takes their screenshots. It isn't included with the app, and the next chapter shows how to get it.

> **About the pictures in this guide**
> The screenshots show a made-up collection of films and TV series, with drawn posters in place of real pictures.

2. Getting started

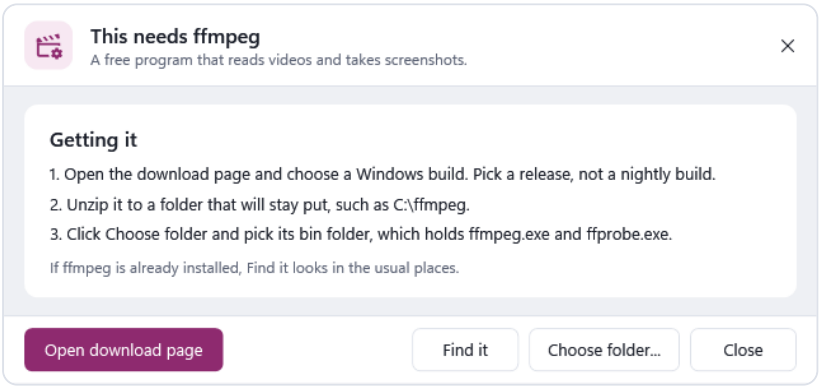
Installing

1. Double-click the setup file, `VideoShelf-Setup-1.1.0.exe`.
2. Choose **Install for all users** or **Install for me only**. Installing for everyone needs an administrator password.
3. Accept the suggested folder, or choose another, and click **Next**.
4. Tick **Create a desktop shortcut** if you'd like one, then click **Next** and **Install**.
5. Click **Finish**. Leave **Open Video Shelf** ticked to start it straight away.

> **If Windows shows a warning**
> Windows can show a SmartScreen message for newly released apps. If you trust where you got the installer, choose **More info**, then **Run anyway**. On a PC with Smart App Control switched on, Windows may not let the installer run at all.

Getting ffmpeg

Until ffmpeg is set up, an **ffmpeg needed** button shows in the status bar, and anything that reads a video asks for it first.

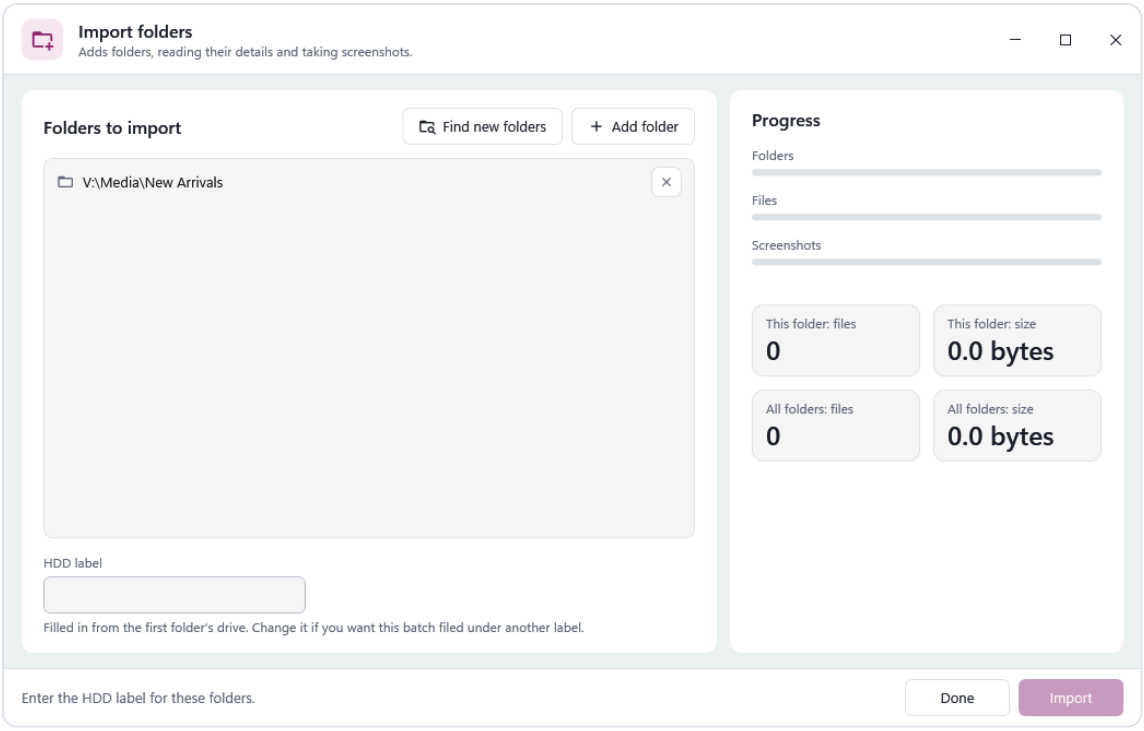


Setting up ffmpeg

1. Click **ffmpeg needed**, then **Open download page**, and choose a Windows release build.
2. Unzip it to a folder that will stay put, such as `C:\ffmpeg`.
3. Click **Choose folder...** and pick its `bin` folder, which holds `ffmpeg.exe` and `ffprobe.exe`. If ffmpeg is already installed, **Find it** looks in the usual places.

Adding your first folder

1. Choose **File > Import Folder(s)...**
2. Click **Add folder**, or drag folders into the window. To pick up several at once, click **Find new folders**, choose one connected drive and search it: Video Shelf looks beside the folders you already have on that drive, and you tick the ones to add. Every folder needs its own name across your collection, even on different drives, so a folder whose name is taken can't be added until you rename it on the drive.
3. Check the **HDD label**. It's filled in from the drive, and you can change it if this batch belongs under another label.
4. Click **Import**. Video Shelf reads each video and takes its screenshots.



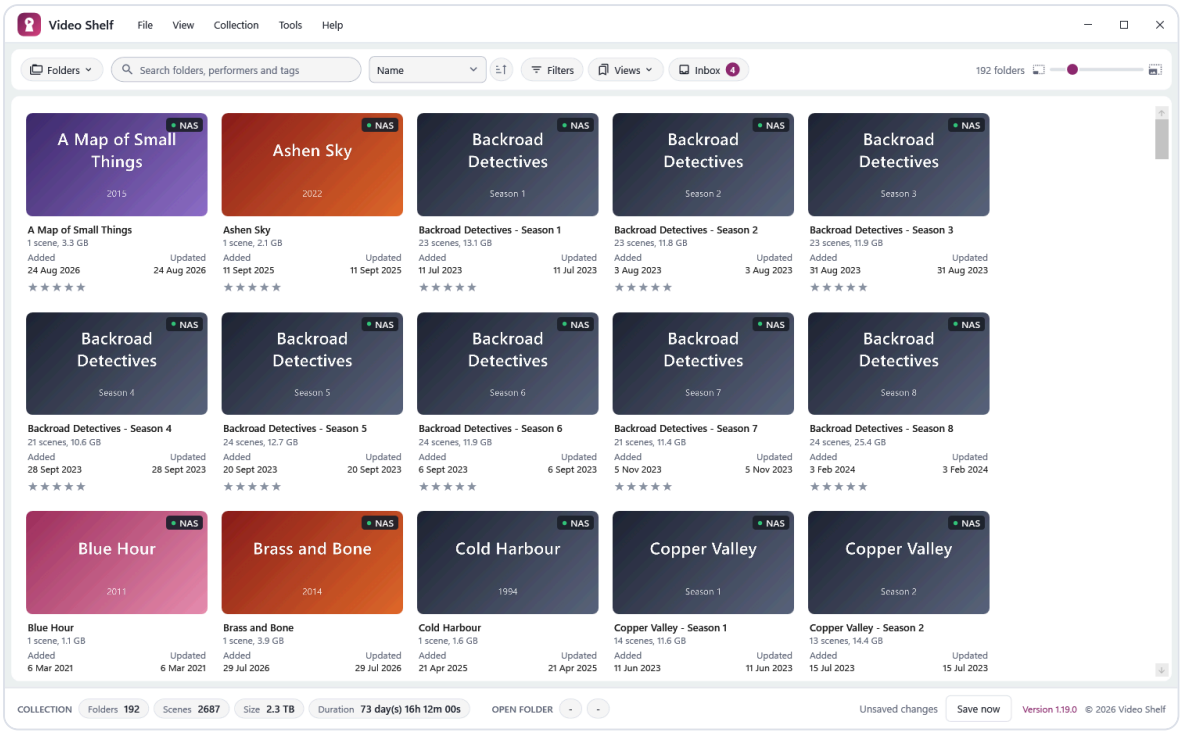
The Import Folders window, with a folder ready to import

> **Your videos aren't moved**
> Importing only adds them to the catalogue. Your files stay exactly where they are.

Uninstalling

Use **Settings > Apps** in Windows, or **Uninstall Video Shelf** in the Start menu. This removes the app only. Your catalogue, ratings and videos stay in place, so reinstalling picks up where you left off.

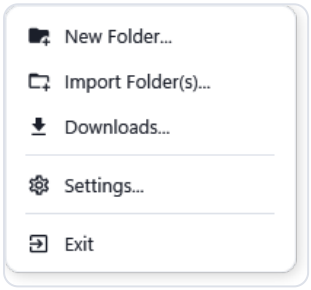
3. A tour of the main window



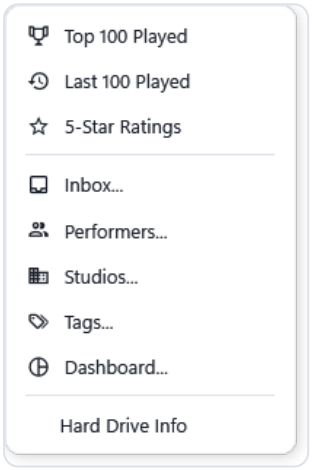
The main window showing folders

The menus

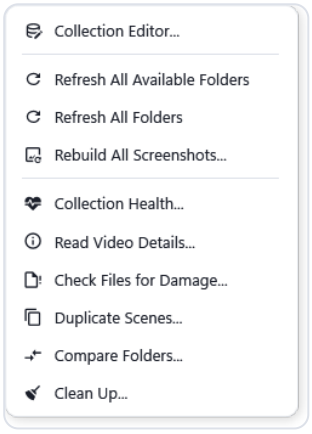
Menu	What's there
File	New Folder, Import Folders, Downloads, Settings and Exit
View	Top 100 Played, Last 100 Played, 5-Star Ratings, Inbox, Performers, Studios, Tags, Dashboard and Hard Drive Info
Collection	Collection Editor, refreshing folders, Rebuild All Screenshots, Collection Health, Read Video Details, Check Files for Damage, Duplicate Scenes, Compare Folders and Clean Up
Tools	Torrent Check, Folder Duplicates, Find by Face, Optimise Screenshots, Favourites sync, copying to a drive (Initialise HDD Cache) and clean-up tools
Help	User Guide, What's New, Check for Updates, Activity Log, System Information and About



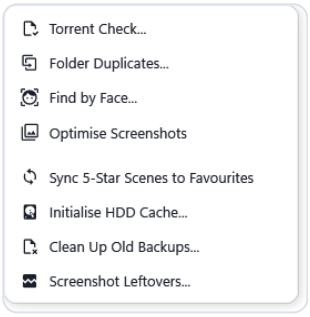
File



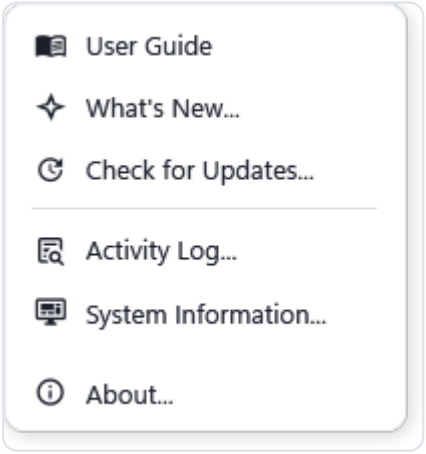
View



Collection



Tools



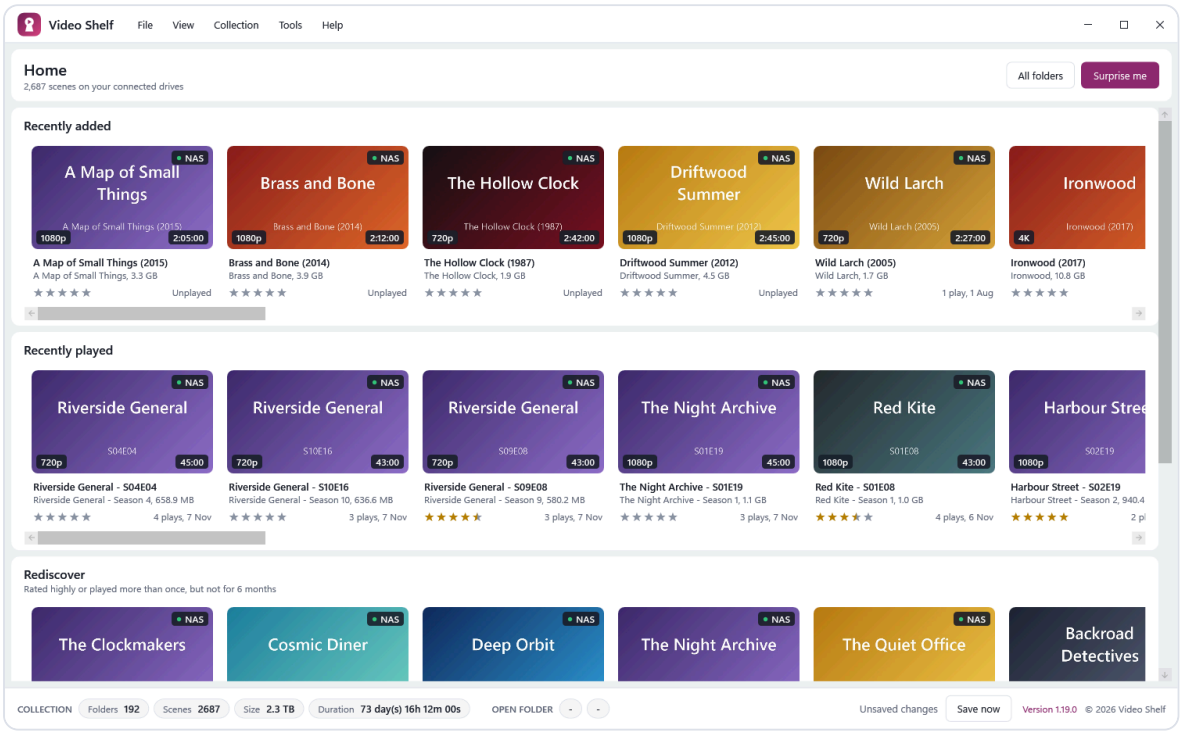
Help

Your own folder details

Use **Settings > Attributes** to add details of your own to folders and scenes, such as Studio, Publisher or Year of Release, as text, a number or a date. Fill them in from Edit Details, or for several scenes at once from the selection bar. Each one becomes a filter for folders and scenes. Scenes can go in categories of their own too. A scene counts as having its folder's categories and attributes, and a value set on the scene takes priority.

Home

Home brings together recently added scenes, what you've played lately, highly rated scenes you haven't watched for six months, and a random handful you've never played. **Surprise me** plays a random scene, choosing from your top-rated ones if you have any. **All folders** takes you back to the folder tiles. The first button on the filter bar switches between **Home**, **Folders** and **All scenes** too.



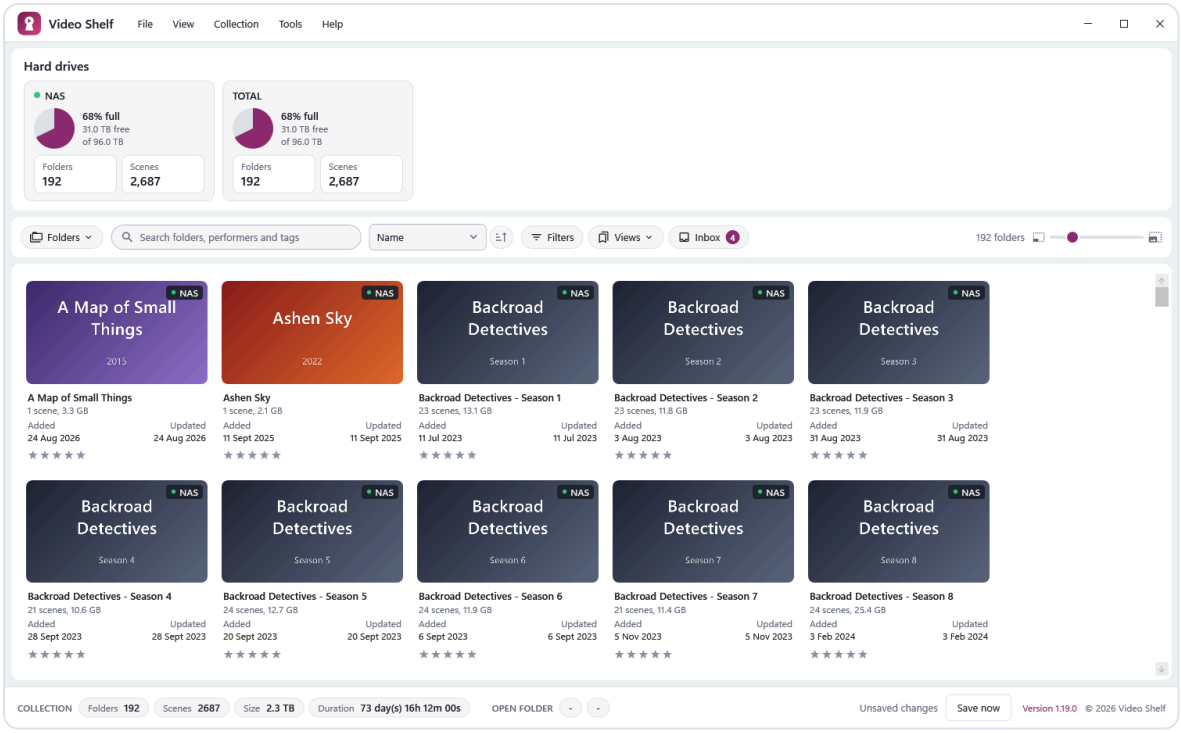
The Home view

Make Home your starting point

Go to **Settings > Display** and set **When the app opens** to **Show Home**.

Hard drives

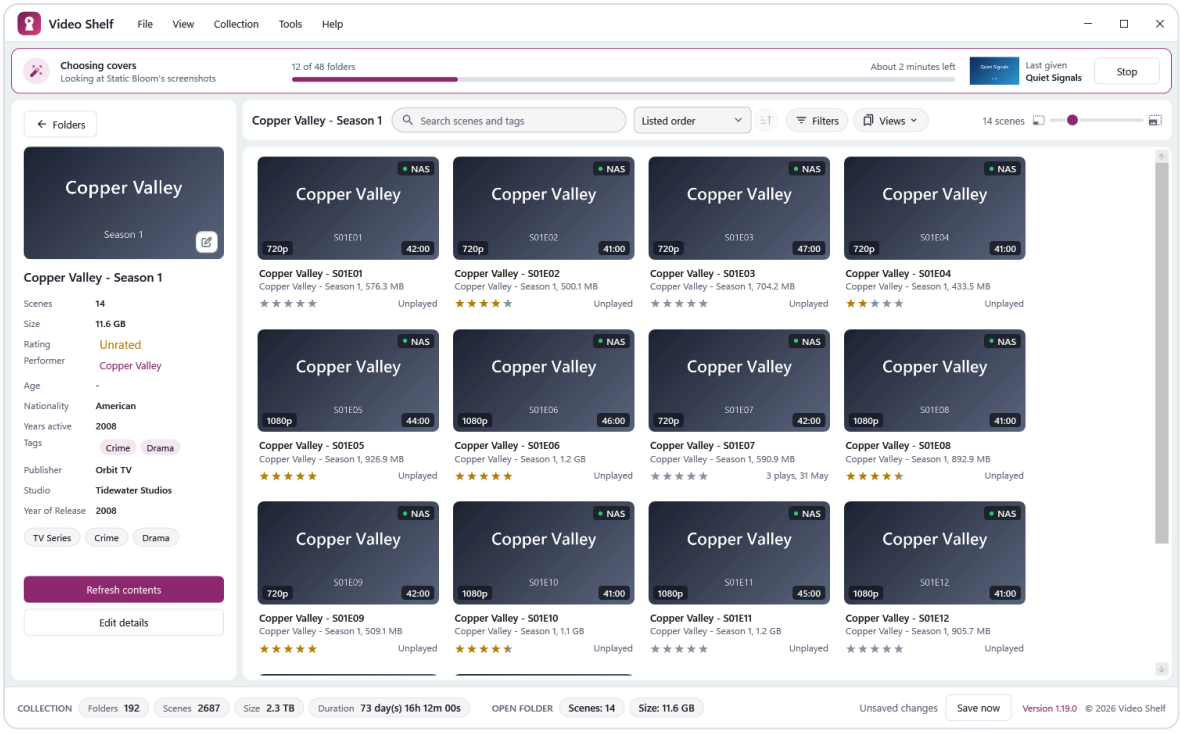
Choose **View > Hard Drive Info** to see a panel listing each drive, how full it is, and how many folders and scenes it holds. Drives remembered in your catalogue are listed even while they're disconnected. Each folder tile shows its drive's label, with a green dot while the drive is connected.



The Hard Drive Info panel above the folders

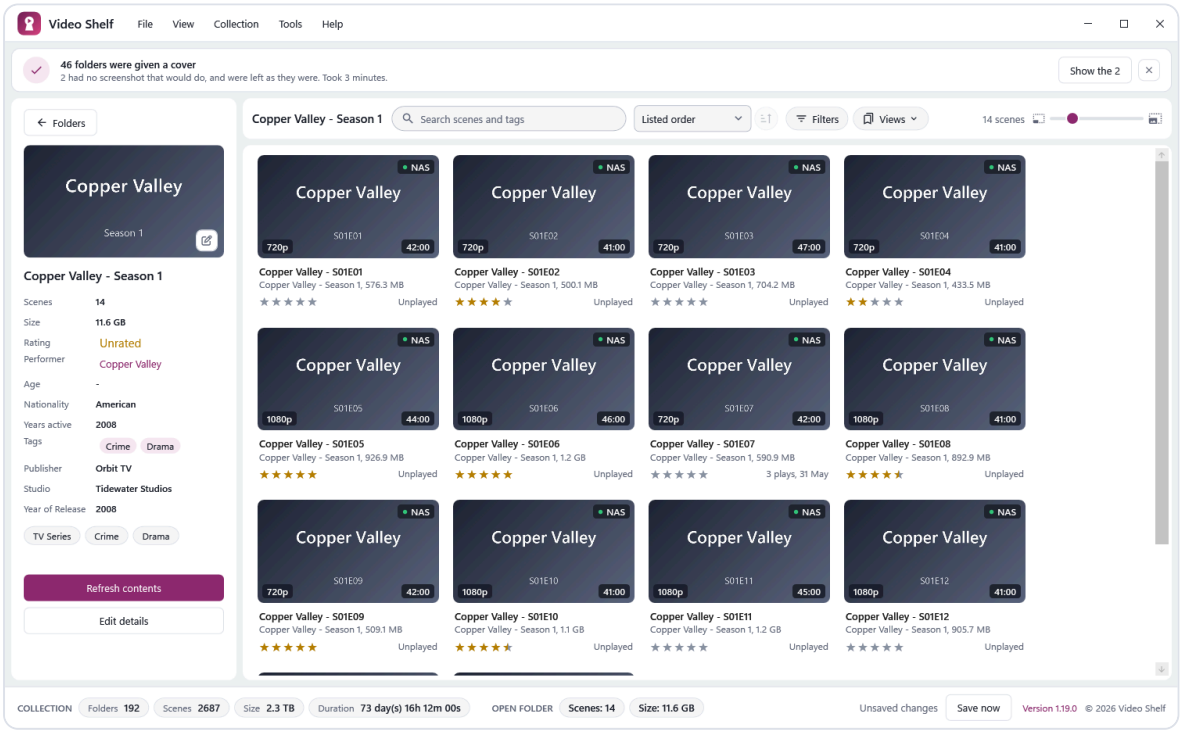
The activity panel

When the app works on many folders in the background, such as choosing covers for them, a panel appears below the menus. It shows what it's doing and which folder it's on, how many are done, about how long is left and the last one finished, with **Stop** to end it early.



Covers being chosen, shown in the activity panel

When it finishes, the panel says what happened. If anything was left out, a button such as **Show the 2** lists those folders. The panel goes by itself after a few seconds, unless the mouse is over it.



The activity panel once the covers are chosen

The status bar

The bar along the bottom shows the size of your collection, the folder that's open, and whether your changes are saved. Changes save by themselves every few minutes, and **Save now** saves straight away. At the right is the version you have: click it to see what's new.

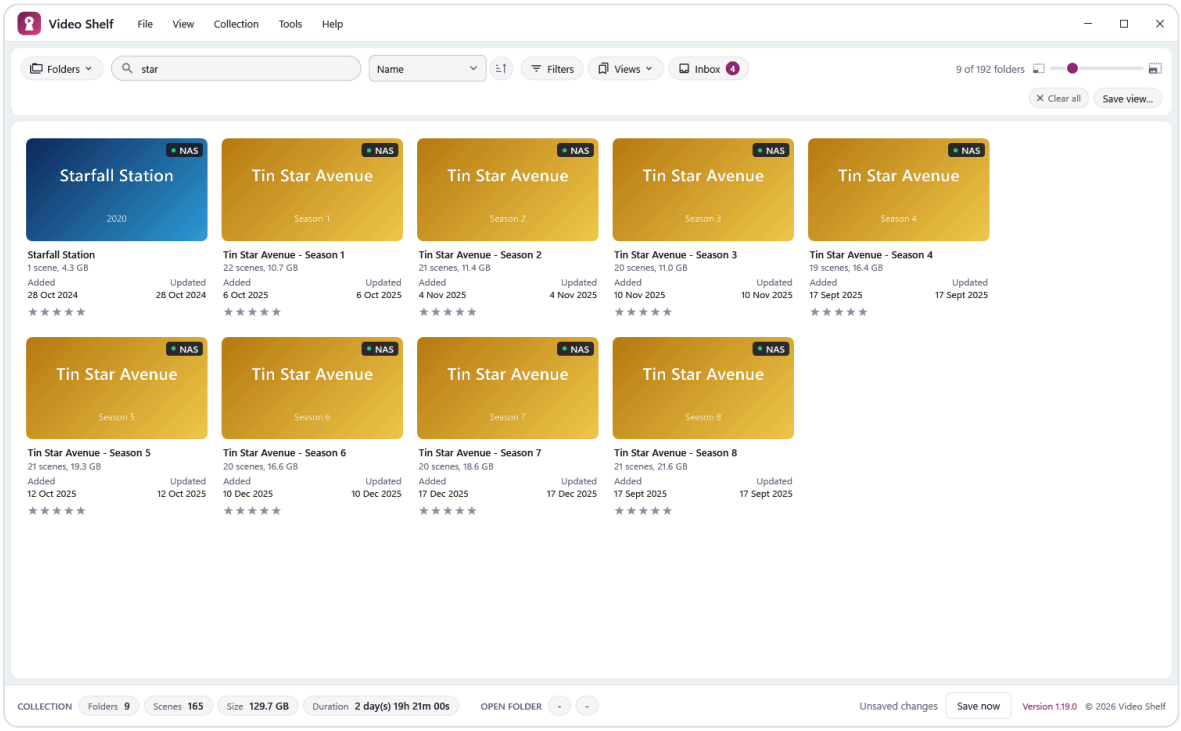
4. Finding folders

The filter bar

The same bar sits above every list of tiles, in the same order: search, sort, **Filters**, **Views**, how many are shown, and the tile size at the far right. Everything applies as soon as you change it.

Control	What it does
Search	Matches folder names, drive labels, performers and tags. Start a word with a minus sign to leave out anything that matches it
Sort	Orders the tiles, for example by name, scenes, size or date added. The arrow beside it reverses the order
Filters	Opens the filters, with a count of how many are in use
Views	Your saved views and the ready-made lists
Tile size	Makes the tiles bigger or smaller. **Ctrl** and the mouse wheel over the tiles does the same

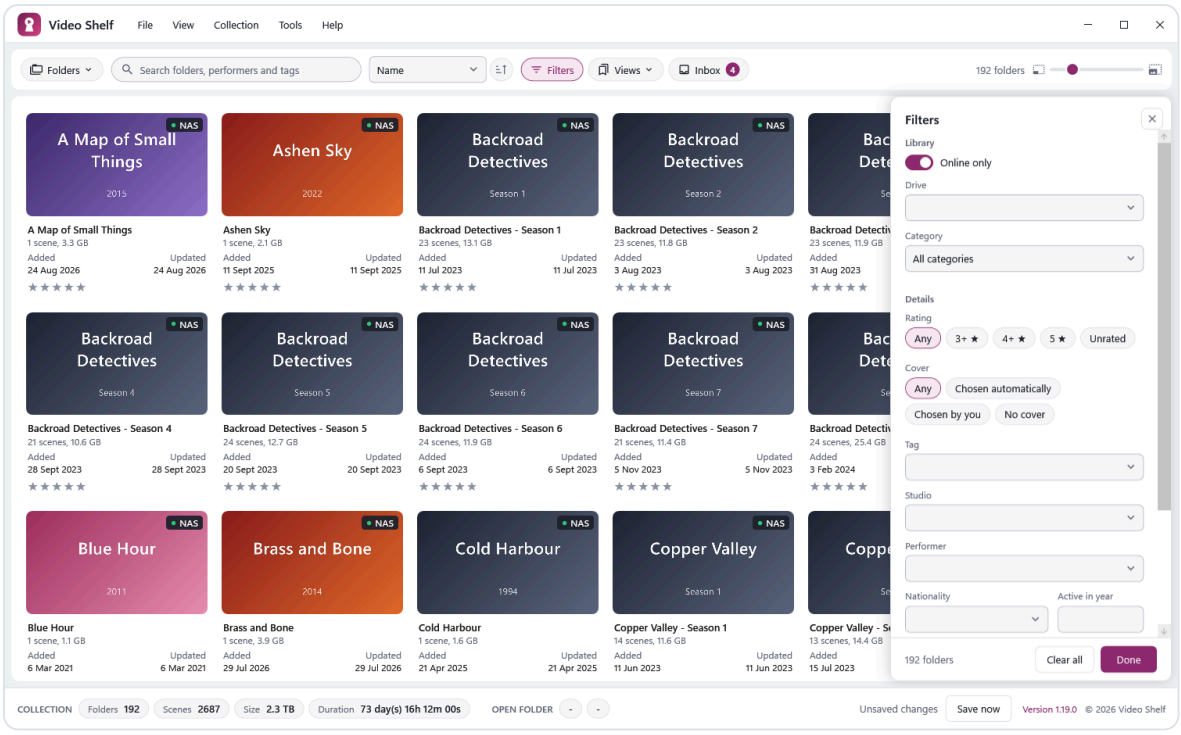
You type	You get
`star`	Folders matching "star"
`star -trek`	Folders matching "star", leaving out any that match "trek"



Folders matching a search

Filters

Click **Filters**, or press **Ctrl+Shift+F**, to open the filters beside the tiles.



The folder filters

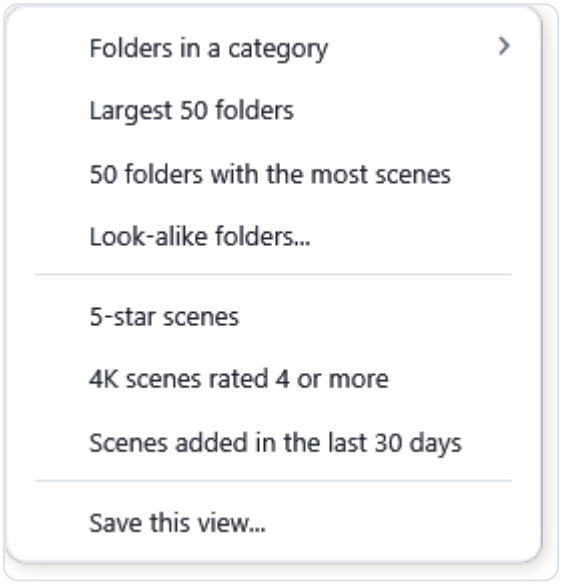
Filter	What it does
Online only	Shows only folders whose drive is connected
Drive	Shows one drive's folders
Category	Shows one category. See chapter 8. Hidden categories can be switched on here too
Tag	Shows folders with a chosen tag
Rating	Folders rated 3 stars or more, 4 or more, 5, or not rated yet
Performer, **Nationality**, **Active in year**	Narrow folders by their performers, including those named only on their scenes
Your attributes	Each attribute you've added, such as Publisher or Year of Release, becomes a filter here

Each filter in use also appears as a chip under the bar. Click a chip's cross to remove that filter, or **Clear all** to remove them all. **Esc** closes the filters.

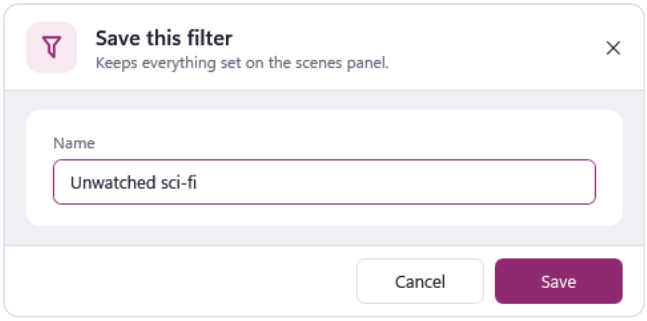
Views and ready-made lists

Views holds your saved views and some useful lists, such as the largest 50 folders, the 50 with the most scenes, folders in a category, 5-star scenes, 4K scenes rated 4 or more, scenes added in the last 30 days, and look-alike folders (see chapter 10).

To save the way you've set things up, choose **Save this view...** and give it a name. A view keeps the search, sort, filters and tile size, and appears at the top of the menu, ready for one click. **Delete a saved view** removes one.



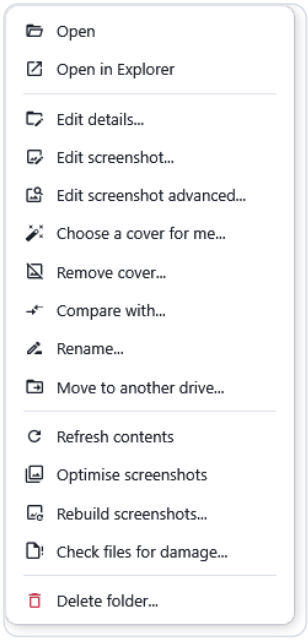
The Views menu



Naming a saved view

The folder menu

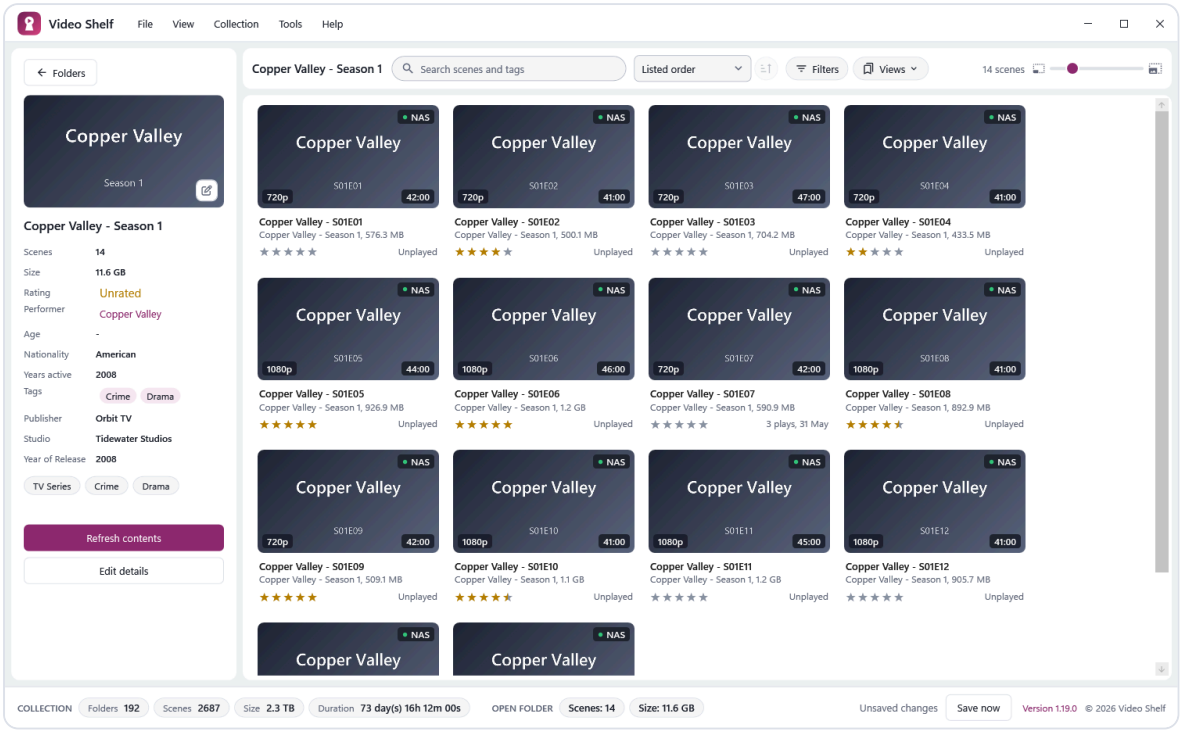
Right-click a folder tile for everything you can do to that folder: open it, open it in File Explorer, edit its details or cover, have a cover chosen for you, compare it with another folder, rename it, refresh it, optimise or rebuild its screenshots, and remove it from your collection.



Right-clicking a folder

5. Working with scenes

Click a folder tile to open it. Its details appear on the left, with its scenes beside them. **Folders** at the top left takes you back.



An open folder with its details and scenes

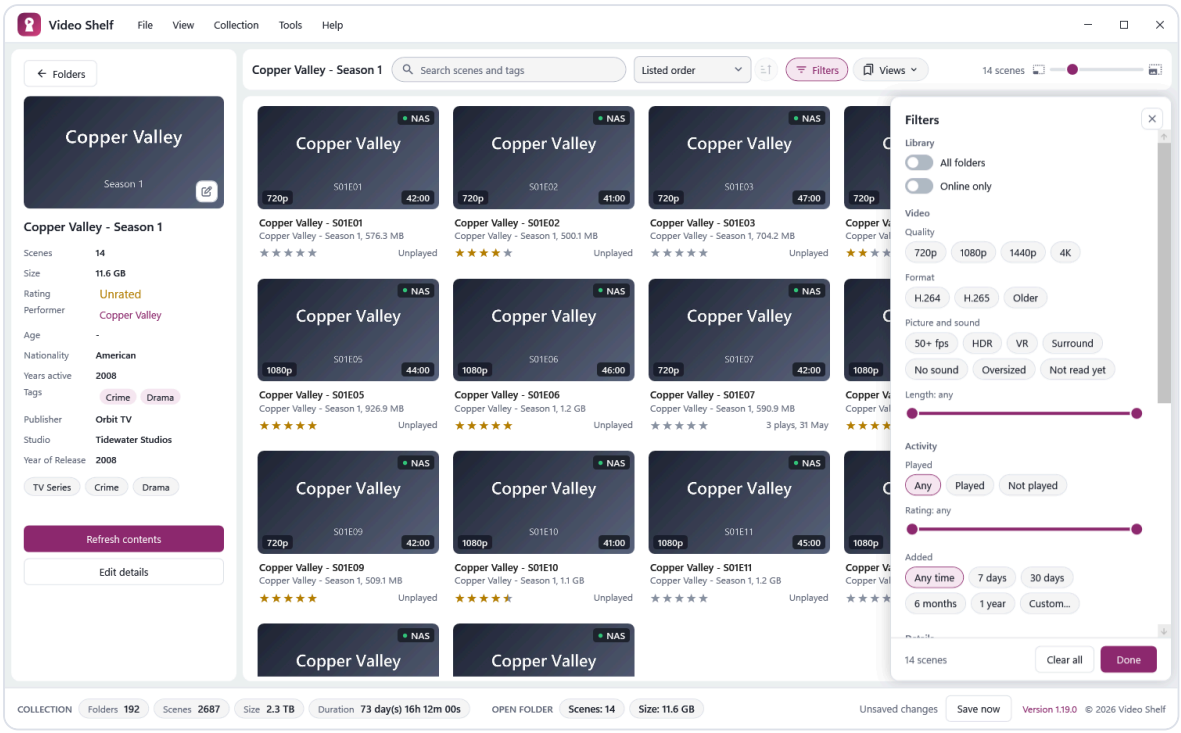
Playing and previewing

- **Play a scene** by clicking its picture. It opens in your default video player, and your play count goes up.
- **Preview a scene** by moving the mouse across its picture from left to right. You'll see moments from through the video.
- **Rate a scene** by clicking a star. Click the left half for half a star, or your current rating again to clear it.

Each tile shows the scene's quality and length on its picture, and its size, plays and when it was last played below. Right-click a scene for more, including its details, trimming it and deleting it.

Filtering scenes

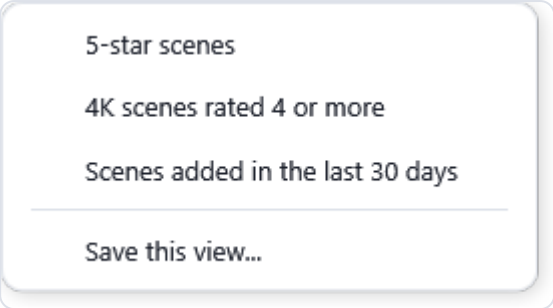
The scenes have the same filter bar as the folders. Search matches scene names and tags, and **Filters** opens these:



The scene filters

Filter	What it does
All folders	Searches every scene instead of the open folder
Online only	Shows scenes whose drive is connected
Quality and **Format**	Limit scenes by picture size and video type
Length	A range, from the shortest to the longest you want
Played	Any, only played, or only those not played yet
Rating	A range of star ratings
Added	Any time, the last 7 or 30 days, 6 months, a year, or dates of your own
Studio, **Performer**, **Tags**, **Folder tag** and your attributes	Limit scenes by studio, performer, tag or detail. A studio or performer counts whether it's named on the scene or its folder, and a scene matches if it, or its folder, has any of the chosen tags

Views works as it does for folders: save the scene filters you use most, or pick a ready-made list.



The scenes' Views menu

Search every scene

Choose **All scenes** from the first button on the filter bar to search and filter your whole collection at once.

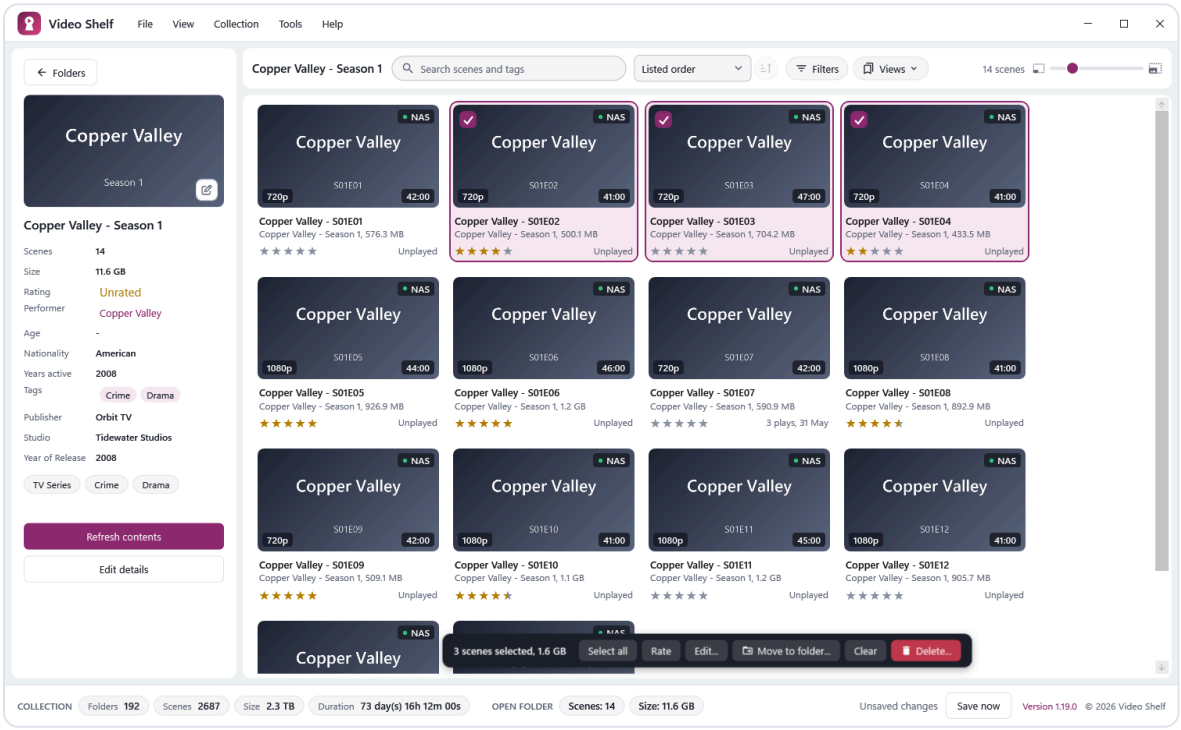
6. Working with many at once

Picking scenes

You can pick scenes in several ways. A bar then appears at the bottom of the list, with what you can do to them.

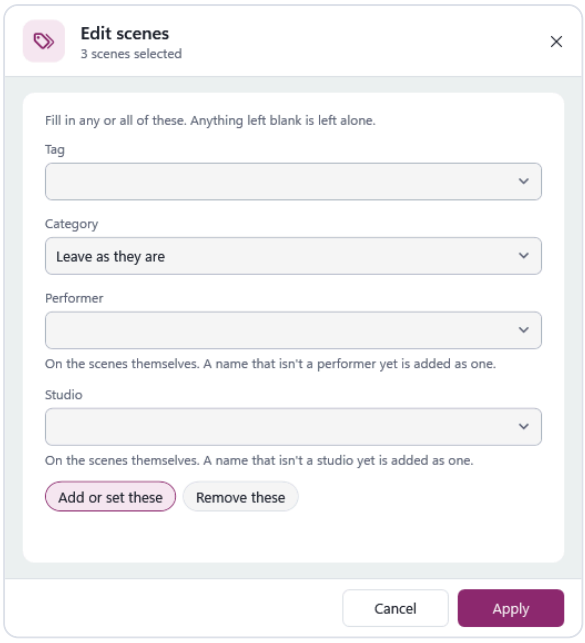
To pick	Do this
One scene	Click the tick box that appears on its tile
Several	Hold **Ctrl** and click each one
A run	Hold **Shift** and click the last one
An area	Drag a rectangle over the tiles, as you would in File Explorer
Everything shown	Press **Ctrl+A**
Nothing	Press **Esc**

Once anything is picked, clicking a tile picks it too, rather than playing it.



Three scenes picked, with the bar at the bottom

From the bar you can pick all, rate the scenes, edit their tags, categories and attributes, or delete them. **Clear** lets them go.



Editing tags, categories and attributes across the picked scenes

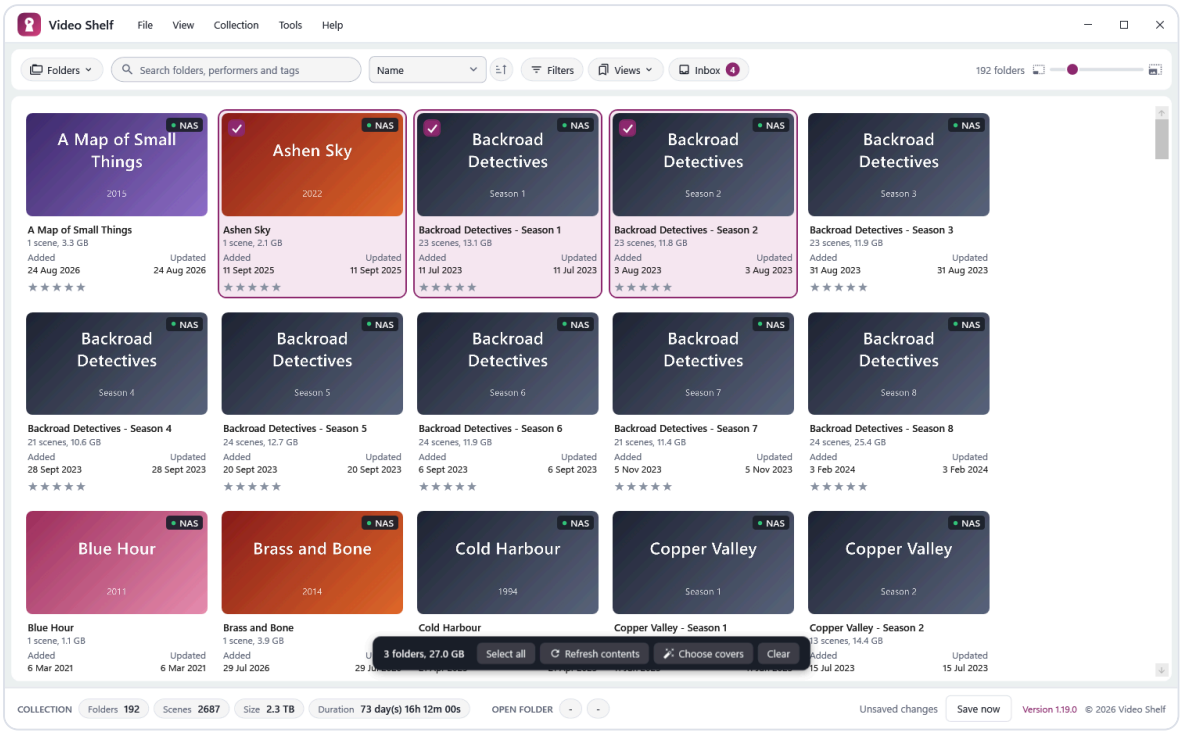
Deleting removes the file

Deleting a scene removes the video from its drive. Files go to the Recycle Bin where the drive has one. Windows has no Recycle Bin on some removable and network drives, so a delete there is permanent. Video Shelf always asks first, and says which kind it will be.

Picking folders

Folders can be picked in the same ways. The bar that appears offers:

- **Refresh contents** for all of them, skipping any whose drive isn't connected.
- **Choose covers**, giving each the best match among its screenshots. If some already have a cover, you're asked whether to replace those too.
- **Compare**, when exactly two are picked. See chapter 10.

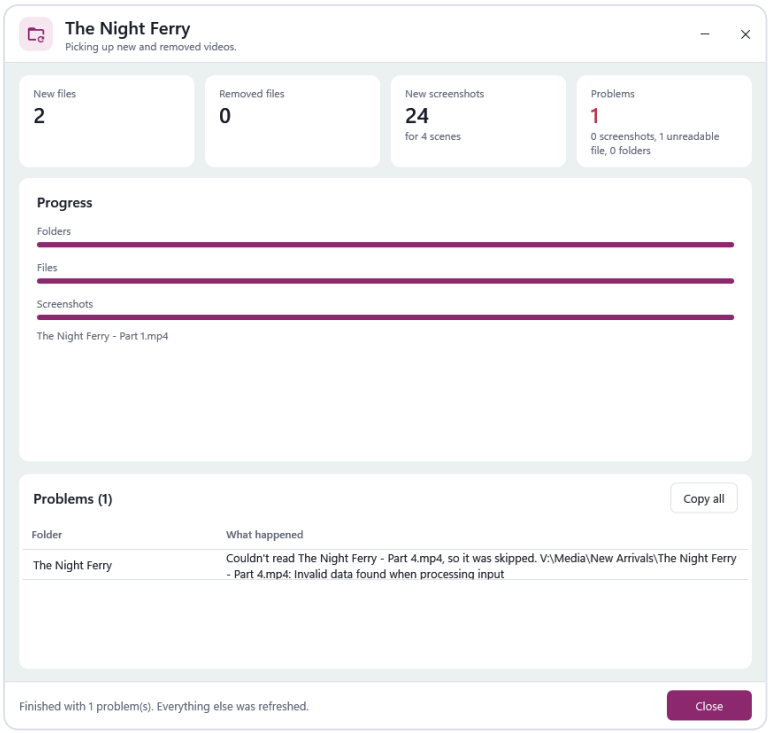


Three folders picked, with the folder bar

7. Keeping your collection up to date

Refreshing folders

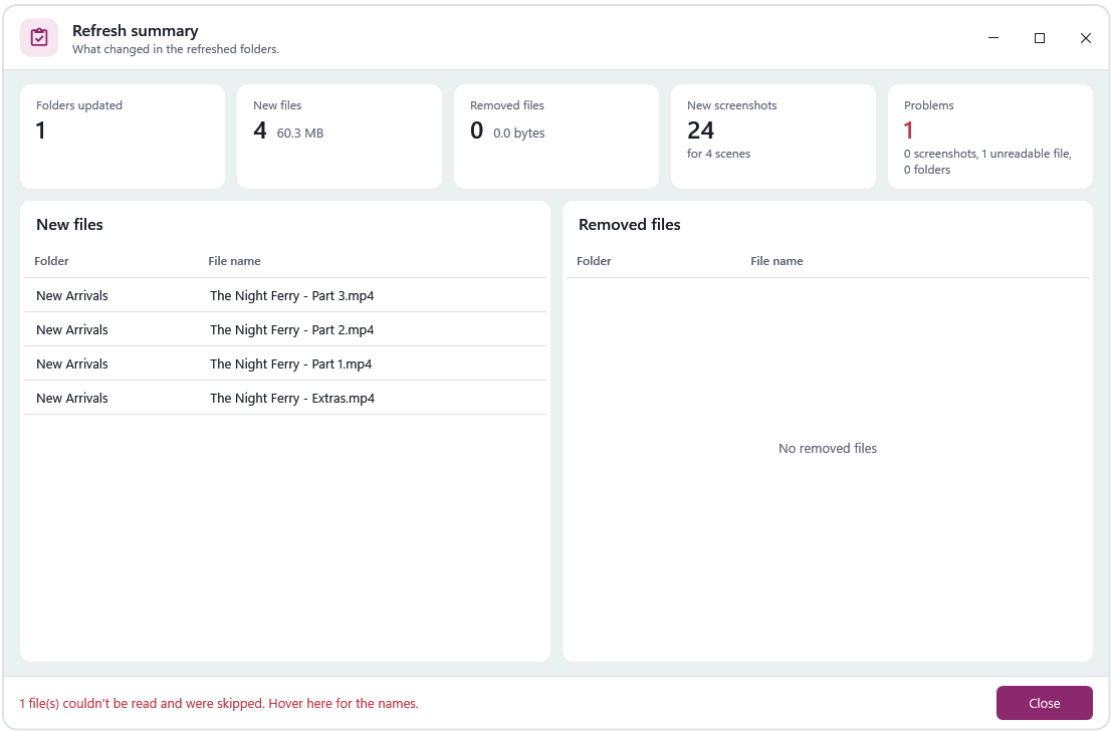
When videos change on disk, refresh to bring the catalogue up to date. Refresh one folder by right-clicking it, several by picking them, or every connected drive with **Collection > Refresh All Available Folders**.



A finished refresh, with one damaged file reported

Tile	What it counts
New files	Scenes added to the catalogue
Removed files	Scenes no longer on disk
New screenshots	Screenshots taken, for new scenes or for existing scenes that were missing them
Problems	Screenshots that failed, files that couldn't be read, and folders that couldn't be reached

A summary shows what changed when it finishes. If anything went wrong, the Refresh window stays open so you can read the details or use **Copy all**.



The refresh summary

Damaged videos

A file that can't be read is skipped, and everything else carries on. Your catalogue isn't affected.

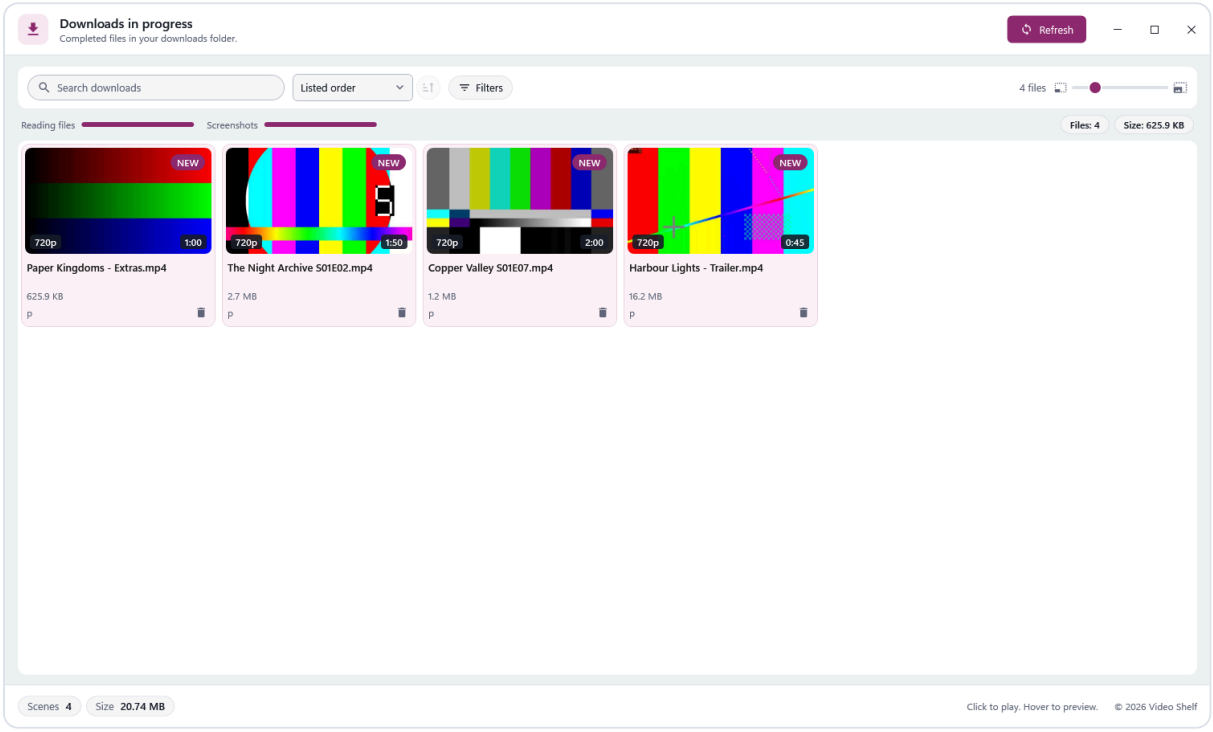
Downloads

File > Downloads... shows completed videos in your downloads folder, chosen under **Settings > Storage**, so you can review them before they join your collection. Move the mouse across a tile to preview it, or click to play. New files are marked, and screenshots are taken in advance to save time when you import them. The folder is watched, so videos appear and leave by themselves; **Refresh** reads it again from scratch.

Downloads has the same filter bar as the main window, with search, sort, length, the folder they're in, size and shape.

Pick several downloads with their tick boxes, Ctrl or Shift and a click, Ctrl+A, or by dragging a rectangle, and a bar appears with what can be done to them:

- **Move to folder...** puts them in another folder in Downloads, or in a folder in your collection on a connected drive. As with moving a folder to another drive, it checks there's room, copies them, checks each copy, and only then takes them out of Downloads, if you've asked it to. Into a collection folder, the folder is refreshed so they're added as scenes, using the screenshots already taken. Within one drive they're simply moved, which is instant.
- **Delete...** deletes them, to the Recycle Bin where the drive has one.

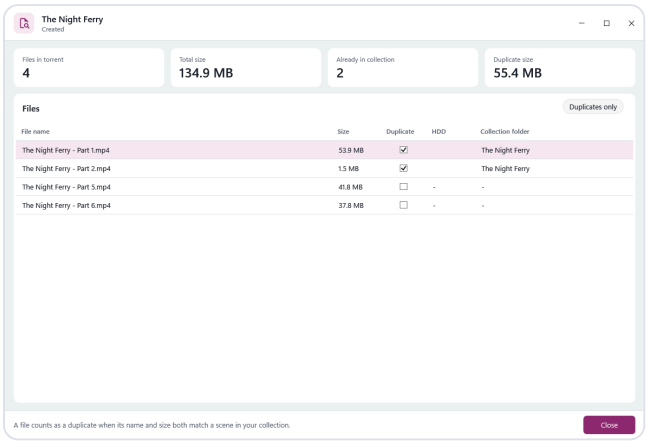


The Downloads window

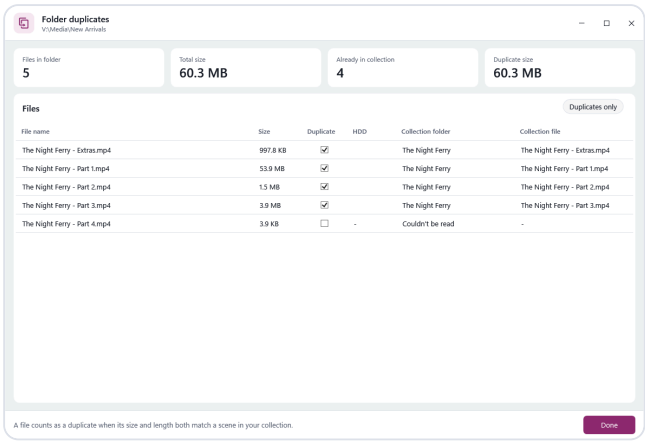
Checking new files against your collection

These two tools show what you already have before you add more.

- **Tools > Torrent Check...** reads a torrent file and marks anything already in your catalogue.
- **Tools > Folder Duplicates...** compares a folder on disk with your catalogue.



Torrent Check



Folder Duplicates, with four files already in the collection

8. Organising your collection

Moving scenes to another folder

Right-click a scene and choose **Move to another folder...**, or pick several and use **Move to folder...** on the selection bar. Choose a folder in your collection on a connected drive, or make one with **New folder...**. As with moving a folder to another drive, it checks there's room, copies the videos, checks each copy, moves the scenes with their screenshots, ratings, plays and tags, and only then removes the originals. Within one drive the videos are simply moved, which is instant. Untick **Take them out of the folder they're in** to copy them instead.

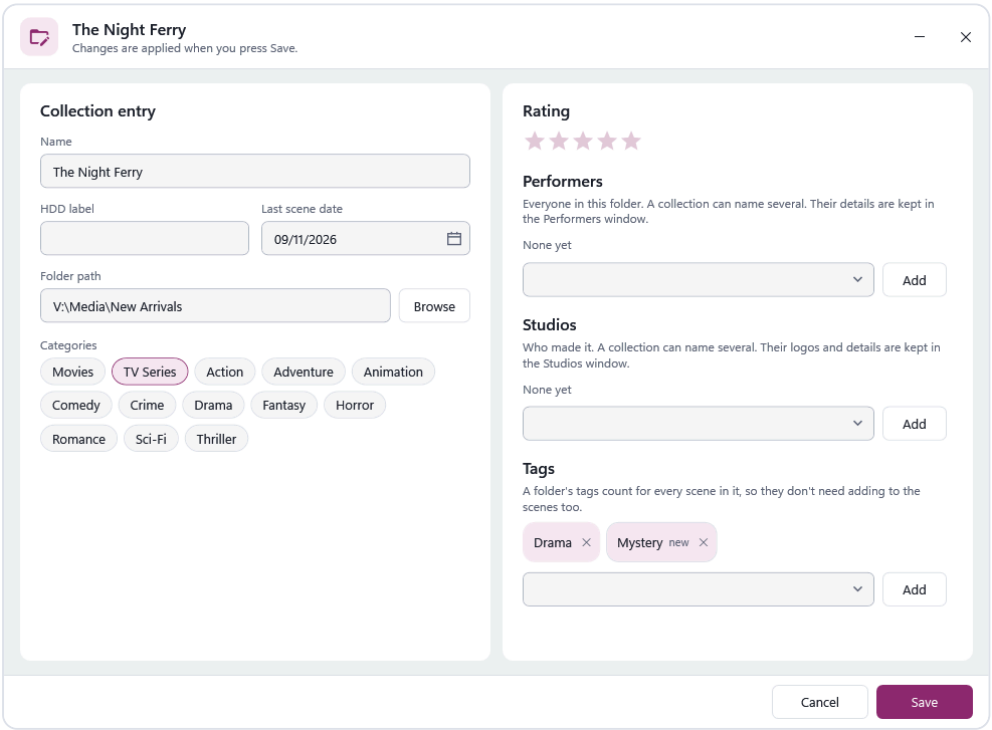
A new folder

File > New Folder... makes a folder on a drive and adds it to your collection. Give its name, the folder to make it in, and its performers. The HDD label fills itself in from the drive. If a folder of that name is there already, it's used as it is, and any videos in it become its scenes.

Folder details

Right-click a folder and choose **Edit details...**, or click **Edit details** beside an open folder, to change its name, drive label, categories, rating, performers, studios and tags. Choose performers, studios and tags from their lists, or type a new name to add one. Performers' details are kept in the Performers window, and studios' logos in the Studios window. Changes apply when you click **Save**.

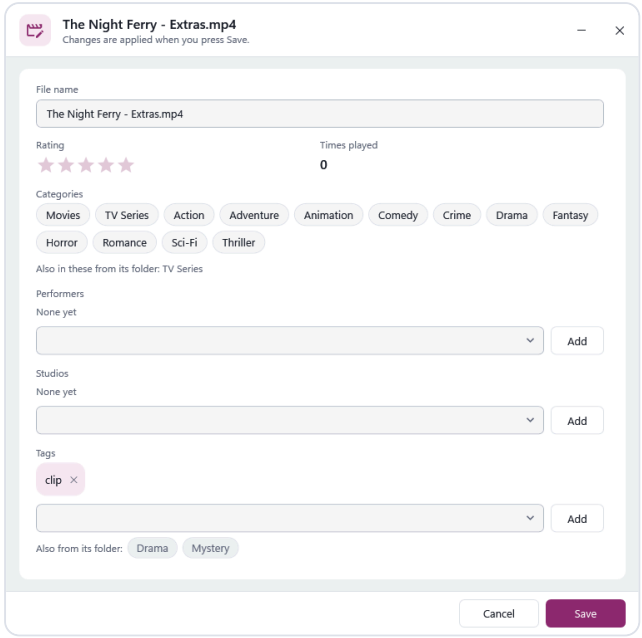
A folder can also be rated straight from its tile: click a star, or the left half of one for a half star. Sort by **Rating**, or use the **Rating** filter to show folders rated 3 stars or more, 4 or more, 5, or not yet rated.



The Edit Folder Details window

Scene details

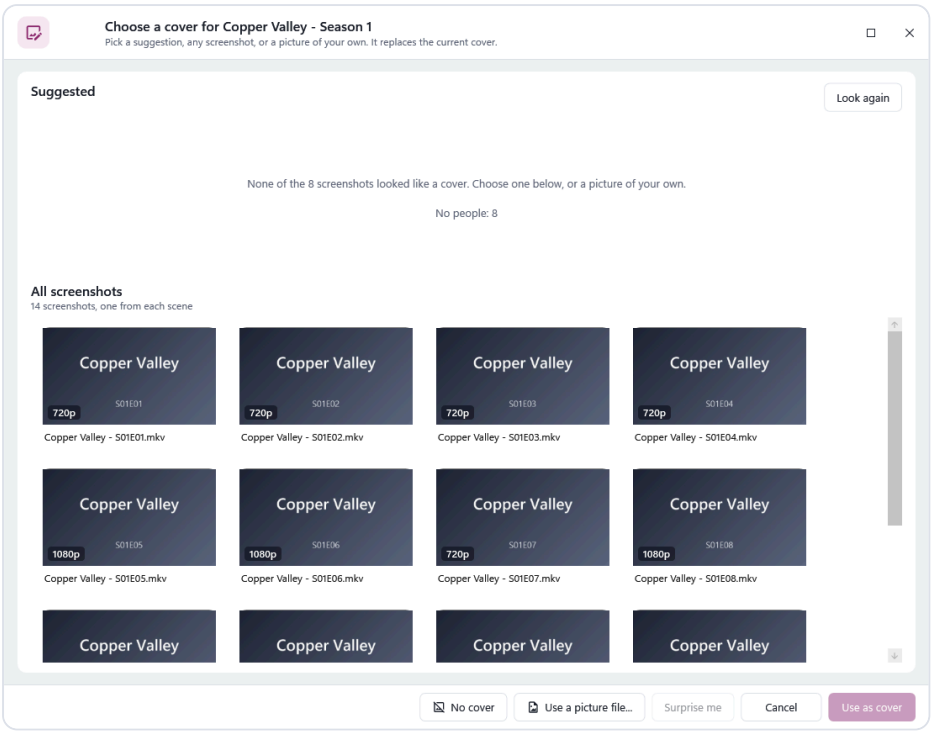
Right-click a scene and choose **Scene info...** to change its name, tags, rating, categories and attributes.



The Scene Details window

Covers

A folder's cover is the picture on its tile. To change it, right-click the folder and choose **Edit screenshot...**, or click the pencil on the cover of an open folder.



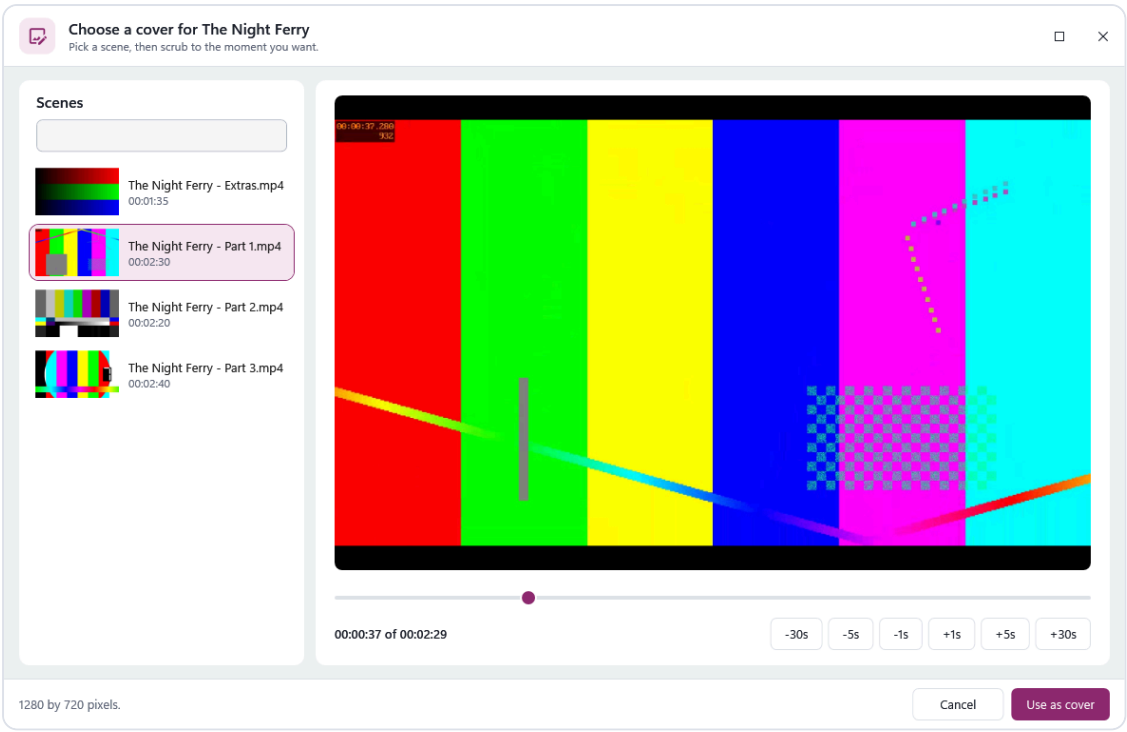
Choosing a cover

- **Suggested** shows the screenshots the cover model rates best, if you've downloaded one (see chapter 12). It prefers one person to two, two to three, filling as much of the picture as possible, and leaves out black frames, title cards and credits. Each screenshot's score is saved, so the window opens straight away next time and only looks at screenshots that are new or rebuilt since. Importing or refreshing a folder, rebuilding its screenshots and trimming a scene score the new screenshots in the background, without changing the cover. **Look again** looks at them all afresh, and **Settings > Covers > Clear saved suggestions** forgets every score.
- **All screenshots** shows the first screenshot of every scene, to choose from by eye.
- **Use a picture file...** uses a picture of your own, such as one you've downloaded.
- **Surprise me** picks one of the suggestions at random.

Choose a cover for me... on the folder menu opens the same window. When the screenshots don't suit a cover, as with the drawn posters in this guide, the window says so and you choose one yourself. To give many folders a cover at once, pick them and use **Choose covers** on the bar. The activity panel shows how it's going.

For more control, **Edit screenshot advanced...** lets you choose any moment of any of the folder's scenes, at up to 1920 by 1080. Its drive must be connected.

Some folders suit no cover at all, such as a collection from one producer. Right-click the folder and choose **Remove cover...**, or click **No cover** in the cover window. Its tile then shows the folder's initial, and covers chosen automatically or for many folders at once leave it alone, even when you choose to replace existing covers. Choosing a cover for it yourself gives it one again.



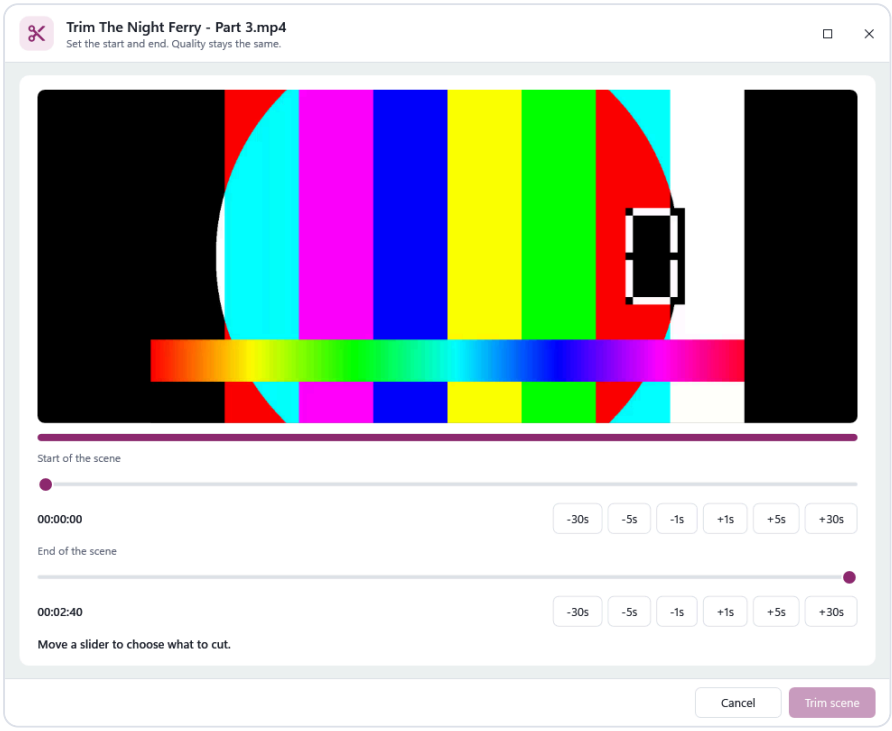
Choosing a cover from any moment of a scene

Trimming a scene

To cut an unwanted intro or ending from a video, right-click the scene and choose **Trim scene...**. Its drive must be connected. Move the sliders, or use the step buttons, to choose where the scene starts and ends, using the picture as a guide. The scene keeps its name, rating, plays and details, and it's given new screenshots.

The video isn't re-encoded, so its quality doesn't change. A video can only start on certain frames, though, so the cut may land a few seconds before your mark. The window shows the frame it will really start on.

The new file is written and checked first, so the drive needs room for it. The original then goes to the Recycle Bin, and the space comes back when you empty the bin. On a drive with no Recycle Bin the original is deleted permanently, and the window says so before you commit.



Trim Scene

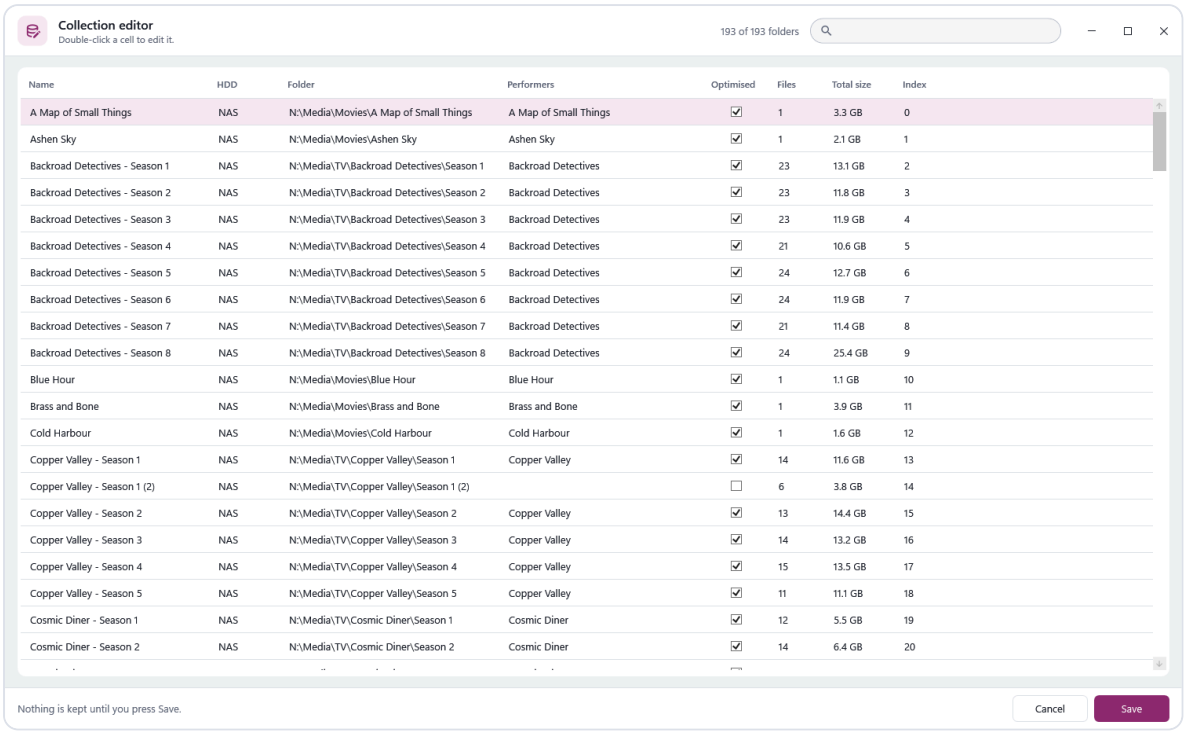
Categories

Categories are your own groups for folders and scenes, such as Movies and TV Series, or genres. A folder can be in several. Create them in **Settings > Categories**, and tick them in Edit Folder Details.

Setting	Effect
Hidden	The category's folders stay out of the folders list, Home and Surprise me until you switch the category on in the filters
Switched off	The category and its scenes disappear from the whole app, except Settings

Collection Editor

Collection > Collection Editor... shows every folder in a table, which is the quickest way to update many at once. Search to narrow the list, edit in place, then save.



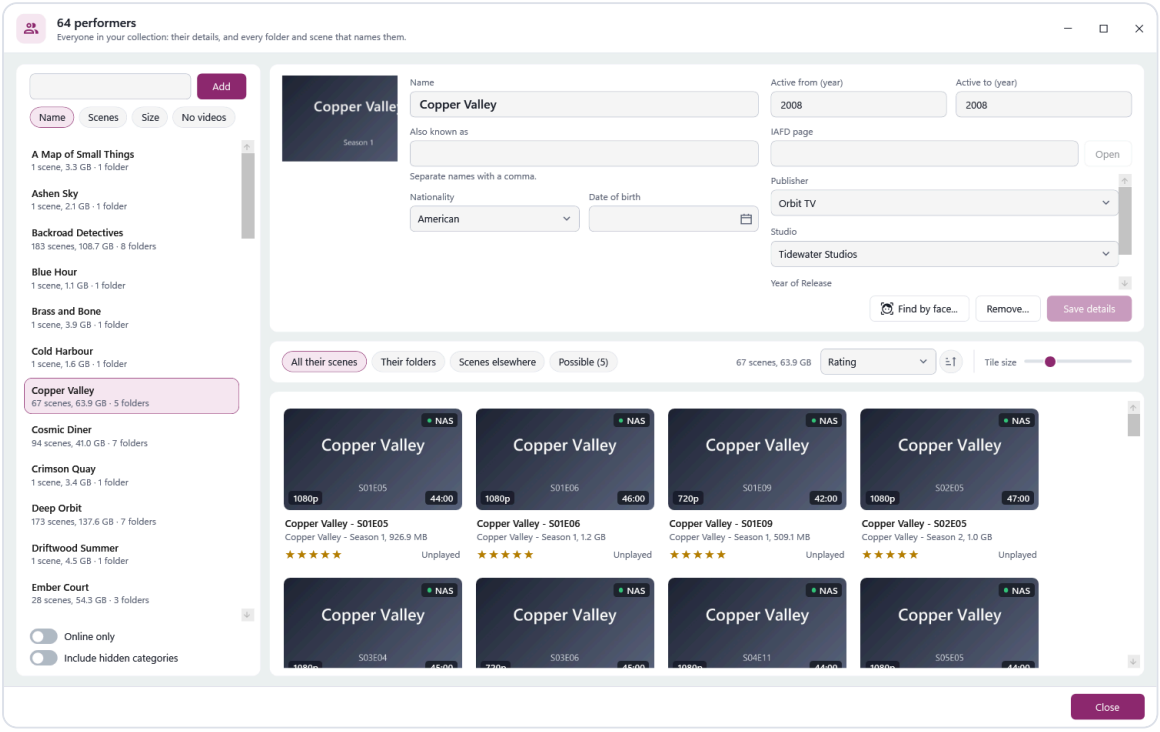
Name	HDD	Folder	Performers	Optimised	Files	Total size	Index
A Map of Small Things	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\A Map of Small Things	A Map of Small Things	☑	1	3.3 GB	0
Ashen Sky	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Ashen Sky	Ashen Sky	☑	1	2.1 GB	1
Backroad Detectives - Season 1	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 1	Backroad Detectives	☑	23	13.1 GB	2
Backroad Detectives - Season 2	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 2	Backroad Detectives	☑	23	11.8 GB	3
Backroad Detectives - Season 3	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 3	Backroad Detectives	☑	23	11.9 GB	4
Backroad Detectives - Season 4	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 4	Backroad Detectives	☑	21	10.6 GB	5
Backroad Detectives - Season 5	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 5	Backroad Detectives	☑	24	12.7 GB	6
Backroad Detectives - Season 6	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 6	Backroad Detectives	☑	24	11.9 GB	7
Backroad Detectives - Season 7	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 7	Backroad Detectives	☑	21	11.4 GB	8
Backroad Detectives - Season 8	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Backroad Detectives\Season 8	Backroad Detectives	☑	24	25.4 GB	9
Blue Hour	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Blue Hour	Blue Hour	☑	1	1.1 GB	10
Brass and Bone	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Brass and Bone	Brass and Bone	☑	1	3.9 GB	11
Cold Harbour	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Cold Harbour	Cold Harbour	☑	1	1.6 GB	12
Copper Valley - Season 1	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Copper Valley\Season 1	Copper Valley	☑	14	11.6 GB	13
Copper Valley - Season 1 (2)	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Copper Valley\Season 1 (2)		☐	6	3.8 GB	14
Copper Valley - Season 2	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Copper Valley\Season 2	Copper Valley	☑	13	14.4 GB	15
Copper Valley - Season 3	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Copper Valley\Season 3	Copper Valley	☑	14	13.2 GB	16
Copper Valley - Season 4	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Copper Valley\Season 4	Copper Valley	☑	15	13.5 GB	17
Copper Valley - Season 5	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Copper Valley\Season 5	Copper Valley	☑	11	11.1 GB	18
Cosmic Diner - Season 1	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Cosmic Diner\Season 1	Cosmic Diner	☑	12	5.5 GB	19
Cosmic Diner - Season 2	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Cosmic Diner\Season 2	Cosmic Diner	☑	14	6.4 GB	20

The Collection Editor

9. Exploring your collection

Performers

View > Performers... is where every performer is kept: their details, and every folder and scene that names them, across your whole collection.



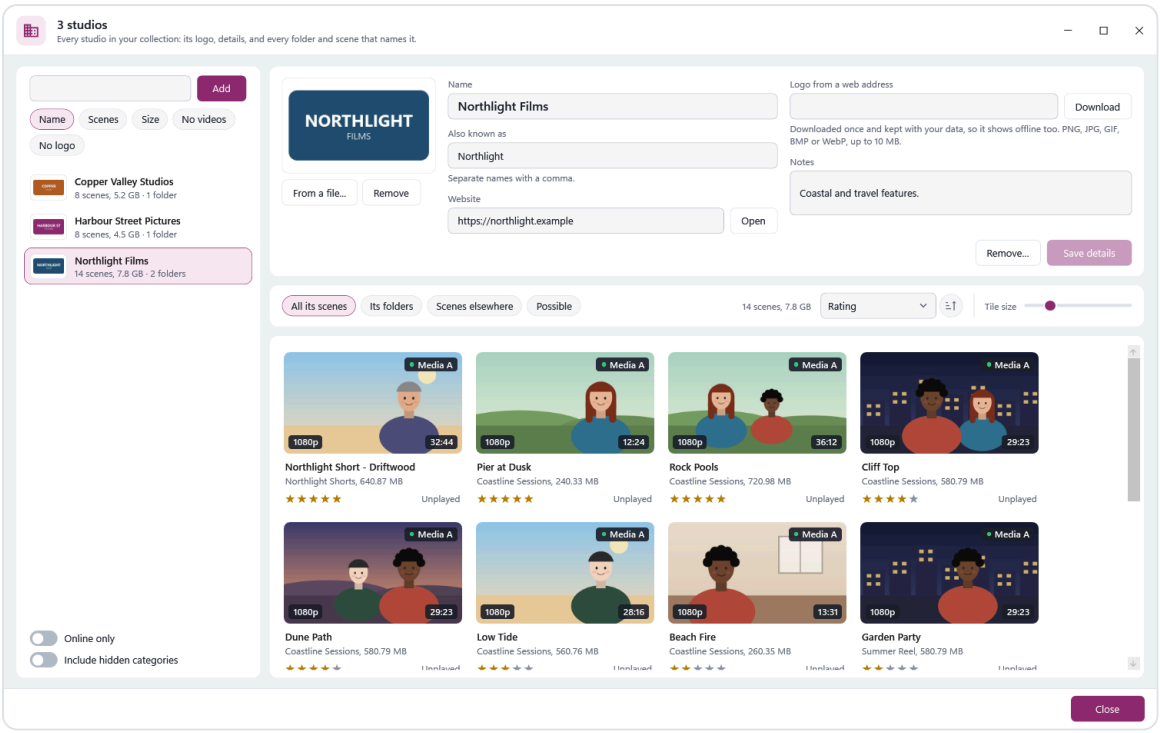
The Performers window

- **Add** a performer, or edit one's name, other names, nationality, date of birth, active years, IAFD page and your own attributes, then click **Save details**.
- Give a performer a name another already has and you're offered to merge them: one keeps the folders, scenes and names of both.
- **Remove...** takes a performer's name off every folder and scene. The videos aren't touched.
- Folders and scenes are given performers in **Edit details**. A folder can name several, such as a collection, and a scene can name its own as well as its folder's.
- **Their folders** and **Scenes elsewhere** show the videos that name them. **Possible** shows scenes whose file names include one of their full names, with a button to name them on those scenes.
- Search by any of their names, sort by name, scene count or size, or show only those with **No videos**.
- Hidden categories stay out unless you switch on **Include hidden categories**.

An open folder's details list its performers, with links that open them here. A folder of one performer also shows their age, nationality, years and attributes.

Studios

View > Studios... works like the Performers window, for the studios that made your videos: each one's logo, details, and every folder and scene that names it.



The Studios window, with a studio's logo, details and scenes

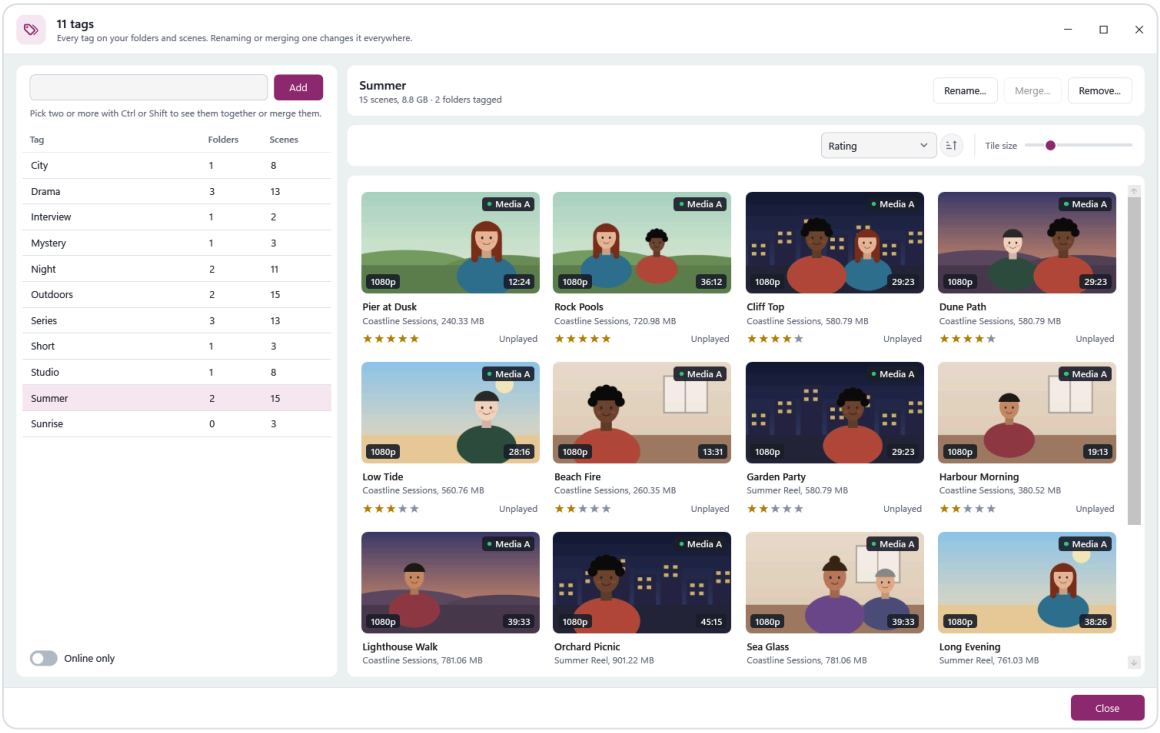
- **Add** a studio, or edit one's name, other names, website and notes, then click **Save details**. A name another studio already has offers to merge the two.
- Give it a logo with **From a file...**, or paste the address of a picture into **Logo from a web address** and click **Download**. Either way a copy is kept in the `studios` folder of your data folder, so it shows offline too.
- Folders and scenes are given studios in **Edit details**, as performers are. A folder can name several, and a scene counts as being from its folder's studios as well as its own.
- **Possible** shows folders and scenes with one of its names in their own name, including the name run together, with a button to name it on them.
- Studios are named for you from file names. Each refresh or import checks every scene in the folder, and a scene whose file name holds a studio's name gets that studio. Spaces, punctuation and joined-up words don't matter, so *northlight.films.scene* and *NorthlightFilmsBeachDay* both count for Northlight Films. A studio is only added this way once, so one you take off stays off. Turn this off in **Settings** under **Name studios from file names**.
- **Remove...** takes a studio's name off every folder and scene, and deletes its logo. The videos aren't touched.

An open folder's details show its studios with their logos, linking here. Both filter cards have a **Studio** box, and search finds studios by any of their names.

Tags

Tags are chosen from a list, as performers and studios are: pick one, or type a new one and press Enter, and it joins the list when you save. A folder's tags count for every scene in it, so there's no need to add them to the scenes as well.

View > Tags... shows the list with how many folders and scenes have each tag. Choose one, or several with Ctrl or Shift, to see their scenes beside it. **Rename...** or **Merge...** changes a tag on every folder and scene at once, and **Remove...** takes it off them all.



The Tags window, showing the scenes tagged Summer

The Performers, Studios and Tags windows are laid out the same way. On the right, the one you chose has its details at the top. Under them is a bar holding which of its scenes to show, how many there are, the sort and the tile size. The scenes themselves sit under that bar. The scenes can be sorted by rating, name, date added, length, size, plays or last played. Each of these windows keeps its own tile size, so making the tiles bigger in one leaves the main window and the others as they were. **Online only** leaves out anything on drives that aren't connected.

Find by face

Find by face looks through the screenshots of your scenes for a performer's face, and offers you the scenes they seem to be in. You check each one, then name the performer on the right scenes in one go. Nothing is named until you say so.

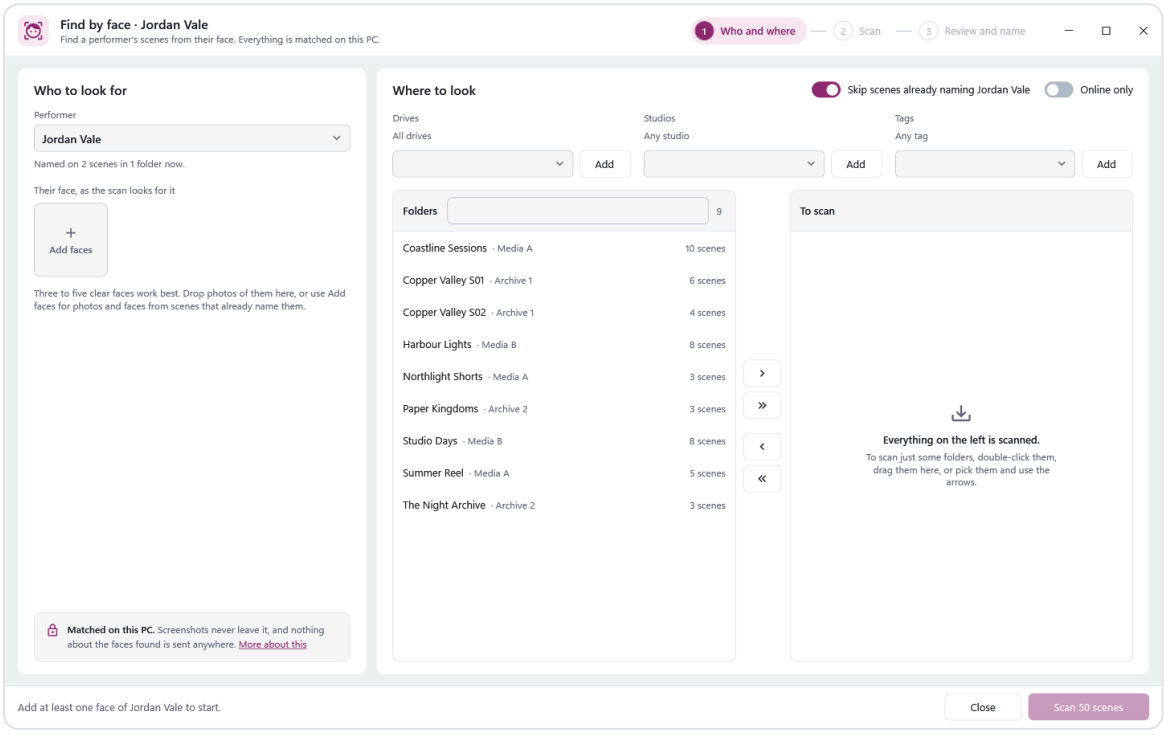
Open it from **Tools > Find by Face...**, or with **Find by face...** on a performer in the Performers window, which opens it with that performer already chosen. The window works in three steps, shown at the top right:

1 · Who and where	2 · Scan	3 · Review and name
Choose the performer, give it a few of their faces, and choose which folders to look through	Each scene's screenshots are looked through for faces like theirs	Check what was found, then name them on the right scenes

> **Before the first time**
> Find by face needs two models, 38 MB in all, downloaded once from **Settings > Faces**. If they aren't there yet, Find by face offers to open that page for you. Faces are matched on your PC, never online.

Step 1: who to look for

Choose the performer in the **Performer** box. Under it you'll see how many scenes already name them. The area below shows **their face, as the scan looks for it**: empty the first time, or the faces you gave it last time. Faces are remembered for each performer, so you only add them once. Click the ✕ on a face to take it off.



Find by face as it opens: a performer chosen, but no faces yet

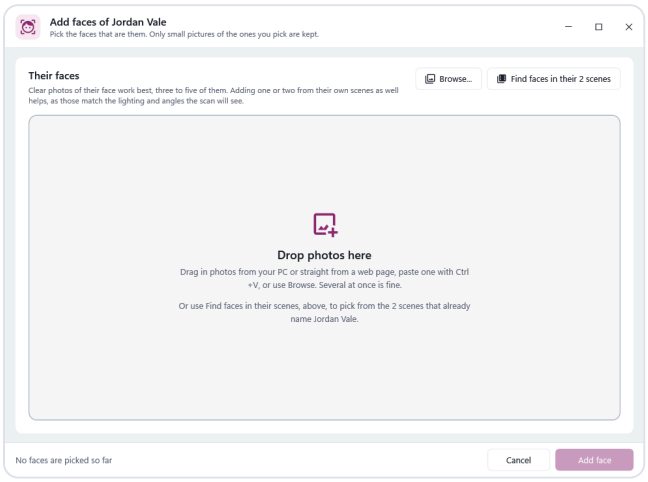
The **Scan** button stays greyed out until there's at least one face to look for. The line at the bottom of the window says what's still needed.

Adding their faces

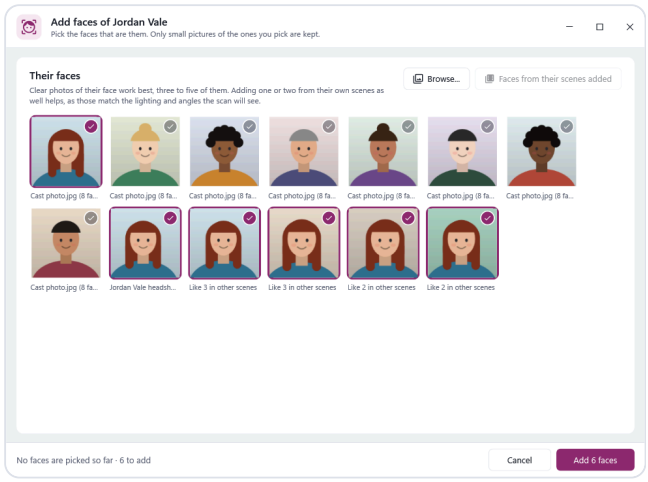
Click **Add faces**, or drop photos of them straight onto the faces area. The **Add faces** window opens ready for pictures:

- Drag in photos from your PC, or straight from a web page.
- Copy a picture and paste it with Ctrl+V.
- Use **Browse...** to choose photos on your PC. Several at once is fine.
- Use **Find faces in their scenes** to look through the scenes that already name them. The faces seen most often come first, labelled *Like 3 in other scenes* and so on.

Each face found is cut out and shown. Click a face to tick or untick it. A photo with only one face is ticked for you. A photo with several, such as a cast photo, has none ticked, so tick the one that's them. Faces you've already given it aren't shown again. When the right faces are ticked, click **Add**.



Add faces, before any photos are added



A headshot, a cast photo with one face ticked, and four faces from their own scenes

Which faces work best

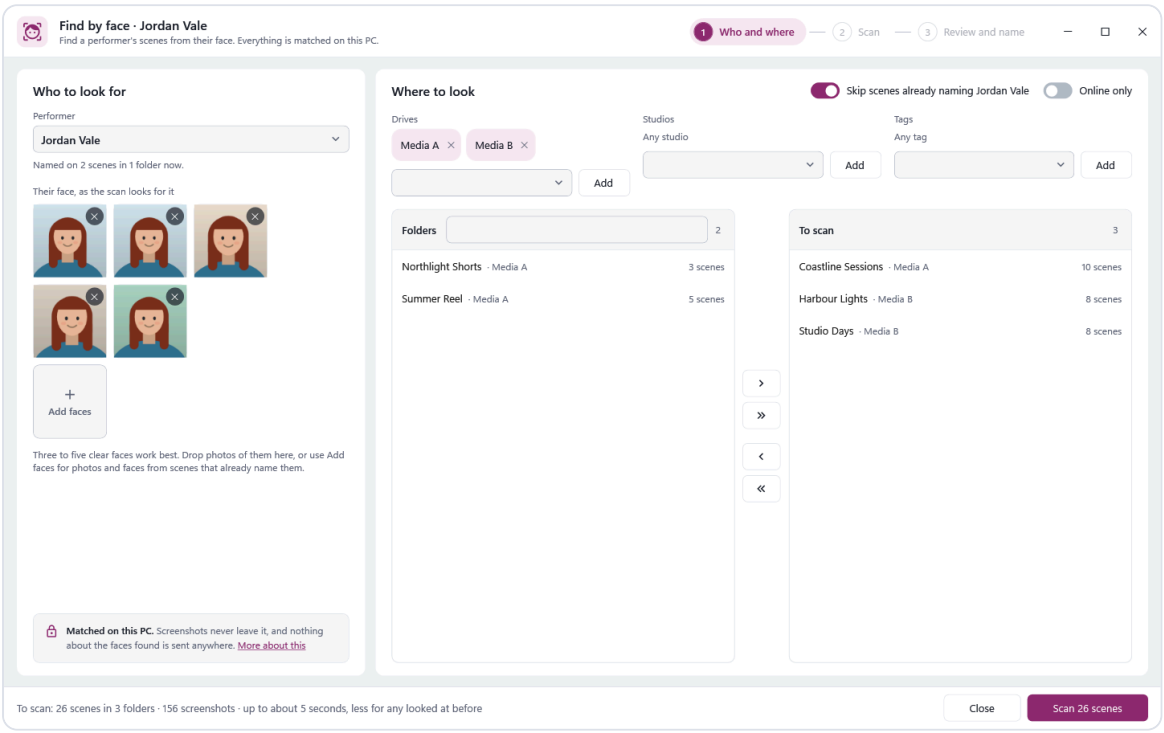
Three to five clear faces, looking towards the camera, work best. Include one or two from their own scenes, as these match the lighting and angles the scan will see. More isn't always better: each extra face gives someone else another chance to look like one of them. A face needs to be at least 36 pixels across to be used.

If a web page won't let a picture be downloaded, save it to your PC and drop the file instead. Only small pictures of the faces you pick are kept.

Choosing where to look

The **Where to look** card on the right chooses which folders are scanned.

- **Drives**, **Studios** and **Tags** narrow the folders listed. Choose one from the list and click **Add**, or leave them on **All drives**, **Any studio** and **Any tag**.
- The **Folders** list on the left shows what they leave, with how many scenes each would scan. Type in its box to search it.
- While **To scan** on the right is empty, every folder on the left is scanned. To scan just some, double-click them, drag them across, or pick them with Ctrl or Shift and use ›. » moves everything shown, ‹ takes the picked ones back out, and « empties the list. Changing the filters afterwards doesn't take anything out of To scan.
- **Skip scenes already naming** them is on to start with, as those scenes don't need finding.
- **Online only** is off to start with. The screenshots are kept on your PC, so folders on drives that aren't connected can be searched too.



Five faces, two drives, and three folders in To scan

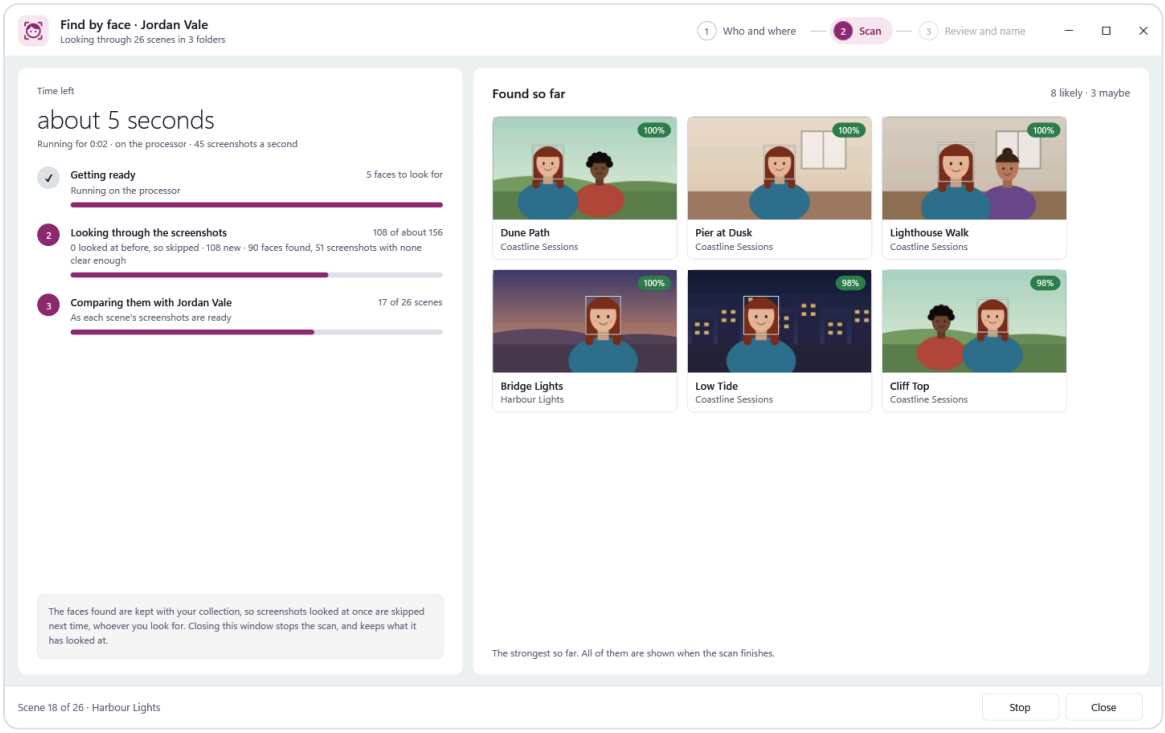
The line at the bottom says how many scenes and screenshots will be looked through, and about how long it could take. Click **Scan** to start.

Step 2: the scan

The scan starts straight away. On the left is about how long is left, and three stages:

- **Getting ready**: the face models are loaded, on the processor or the graphics card.
- **Looking through the screenshots**: each scene's six screenshots are searched for faces. Screenshots looked at in an earlier scan are skipped, whoever you looked for then, so the next search is much quicker.
- **Comparing them with** the performer: each face found is compared with theirs, scene by scene.

On the right, **Found so far** shows the strongest matches as they come in, with how many are likely and how many maybe.



A scan part-way through

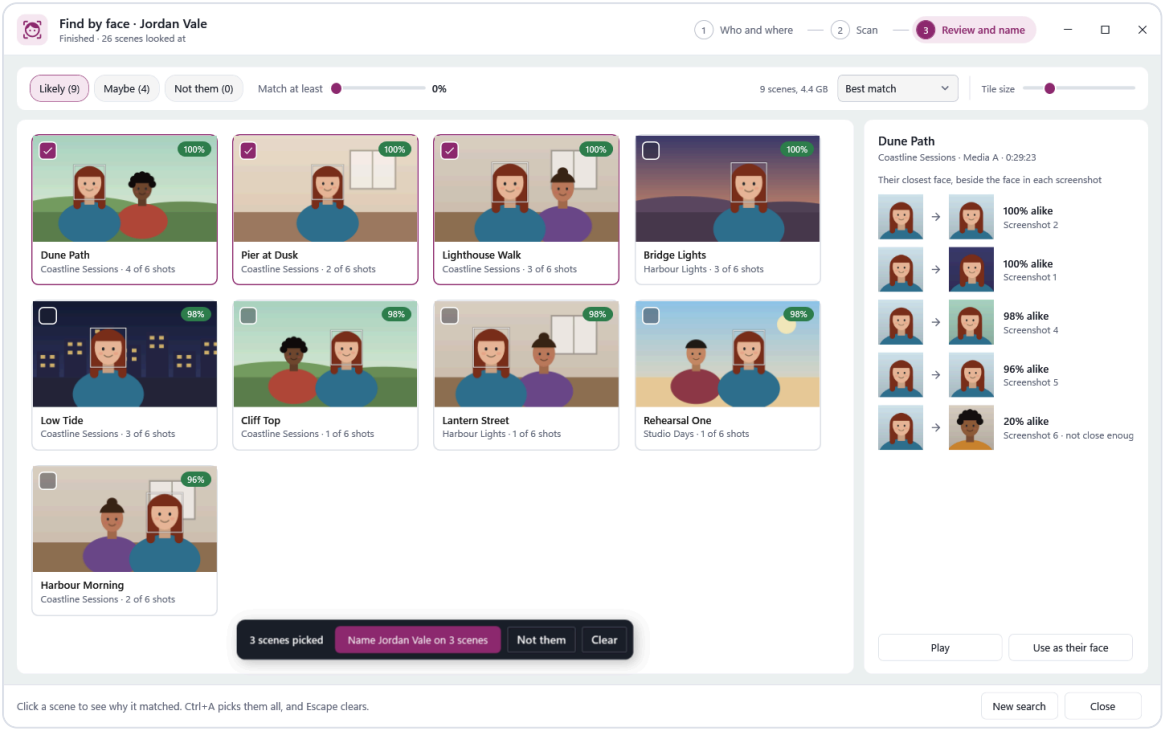
Stop ends the scan early and shows what it has found. Closing the window stops it too. Either way, the screenshots it has looked at are remembered, so starting again picks up quickly.

Step 3: review and name

When the scan finishes, the scenes it found are shown in three groups, chosen with the buttons along the top:

Group	What's in it
Likely	Two or more screenshots match, or one matches very closely. Green score
Maybe	A face that's close, but not close enough to be sure, often from just one screenshot. Amber score
Not them	Scenes you've said aren't them. They aren't offered again. Grey score

Each scene shows its best screenshot with the face outlined, how alike that face is, and how many of its six screenshots matched.



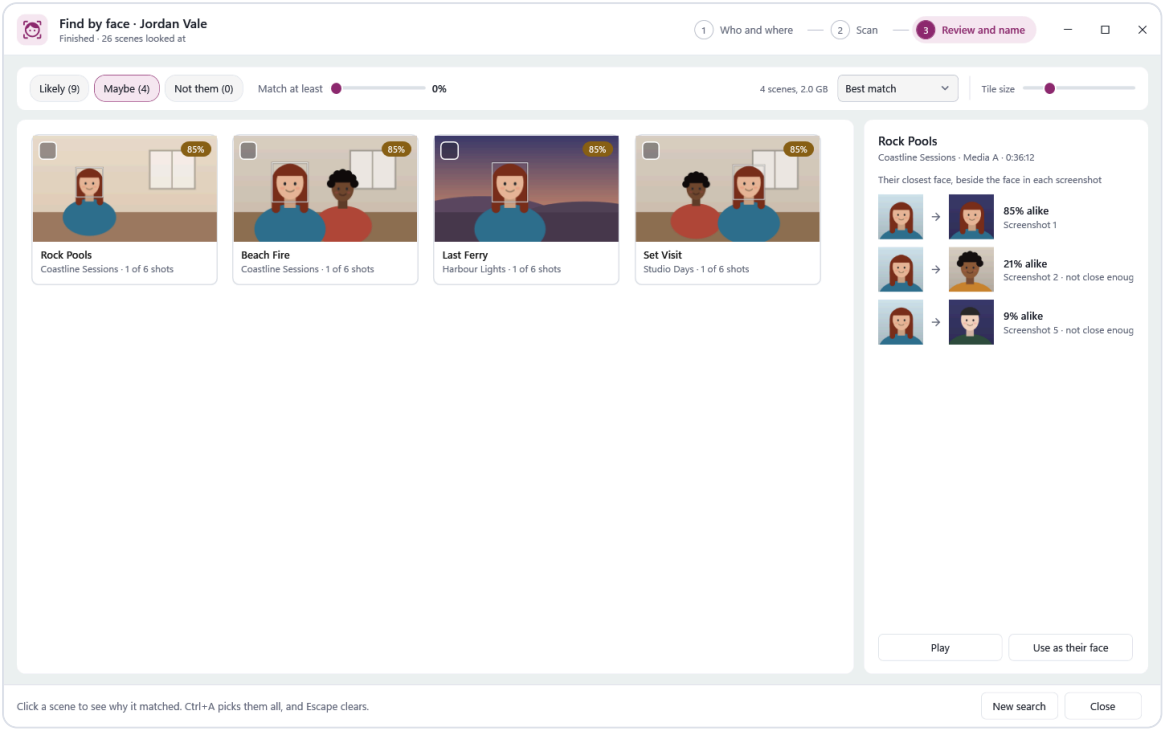
Likely matches: one scene clicked to see why it matched, and three picked

- **Click a scene** to see why it matched. On the right, their closest face is shown beside the face from each screenshot, with how alike the two are. Faces that weren't close enough say so. With **Compare with all their faces on average** on, the figure is how alike the face is to all of theirs. **Play**, or double-clicking the scene, plays it.
- **Pick scenes** with their tick boxes, Ctrl or Shift and a click, or by dragging a box around them. Ctrl+A picks them all, and Escape clears.
- With scenes picked, the bar at the bottom offers **Name** them on those scenes, **Not them** or **Clear**. In the Not them group, **Put back** offers scenes again.
- **Use as their face** adds the scene's best face to the faces the scan looks for. It's a good way to add a face from their own footage.
- **Match at least** hides scenes whose best face is less alike than the figure chosen. The sort box orders scenes by **Best match**, **Most screenshots**, **Name** or **Folder**. The tile size slider, or Ctrl and the mouse wheel, makes the tiles bigger or smaller.

New search goes back to step 1 for someone else or more folders. The step buttons at the top move between the steps once a scan has run.

Checking the Maybe group

A Maybe can still have a high score. A scene where just one screenshot came out close lands here, because one screenshot isn't enough to be sure. Click each one and compare the faces on the right before naming.



Maybe: one screenshot matched, and the others didn't

Why a Maybe can look nothing like them

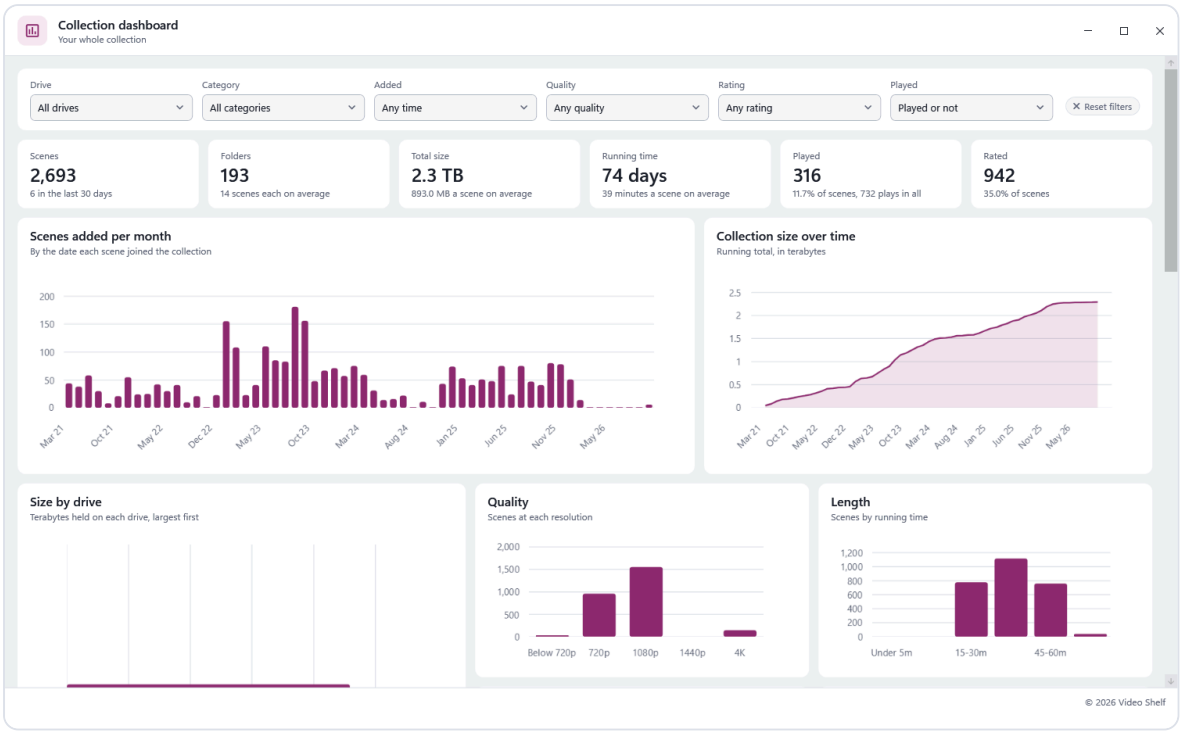
Only the face itself is compared: eyes, nose, mouth and the shape between them. Hair, clothes and the setting are left out on purpose, so a change of hairstyle doesn't hide someone. It also means that someone with different hair can be offered if their face is similar, especially side-on, in low light or from far away. If you see a lot of these:

- move **Settings > Faces > How alike a face must be to count** to the right, for fewer near misses
- try **Settings > Faces > Compare with all their faces on average**, so someone who looks like just one of their faces scores lower
- raise **Match at least**, or stay on the Likely group
- keep to three to five clear faces, and use **Not them** on the wrong scenes so they aren't offered again

Nothing is named until you've checked it. What's kept for each face found is a short list of numbers used to compare faces, not a picture. **Settings > Faces** says more, and can delete it all.

Dashboard

View > Dashboard... opens a dashboard of your collection. Use the filters along the top to focus on one drive, category, period, quality, rating or play status, and every chart updates to match.



The Dashboard

10. Keeping things tidy

Inbox

The **Inbox** button beside **Views**, or **View > Inbox...**, lists what's new or needs a look, a group at a time: new downloads, newly added folders, folders without a cover or performers, scenes added in the last 30 days without tags, damaged files, and what the tagging rules did this week. The number on the button counts what's arrived or gone wrong.

- Each row has what can be done about it there, such as **Open**, **Edit details**, **Choose cover...**, **Add tags...** or **Take the tag off**. Something dealt with leaves the list by itself.
- The tick clears a row, and **Clear all** or **Mark all as seen** clears a whole group. Cleared rows stay out for 30 days.
- **Folders without a cover** can all be given their best suggestion at once.

Video details

Each scene's frame rate, bit rate, HDR, sound and whether it's made for VR are read with ffprobe after a folder is imported or refreshed. For the scenes already in your collection, choose **Collection > Read Video Details...**: it reads only the start of each file, about a tenth of a second each, runs in the background and can be stopped.

- A scene's tile shows its frame rate at 50 or more, and HDR or VR, beside its quality, such as **1080p60 HDR**. Its tooltip lists everything, including how many gigabytes it takes for each hour.
- The scene filters have **Picture and sound** chips: 50+ fps, HDR, VR, Surround, No sound, Oversized, and Not read yet. **Oversized** picks out scenes that take more room than usual for their quality, the ones most worth re-encoding.

Tagging short scenes

Scenes shorter than 2 minutes are tagged **clip** as they're imported or refreshed. Change the length or the tag, or switch it off, under **Settings > Storage > Tag short scenes**, where **Tag existing scenes now** tags the short scenes already in your collection. A tag already on a scene is left alone.

Checking files for damage

Collection > Check Files for Damage... has ffmpeg read the videos of the folders on show, or right-click a folder and choose **Check files for damage...** for just that one. It runs in the background, and damaged files are tagged **corrupt** so they're easy to find. Click **Show them** when it finishes to list them.

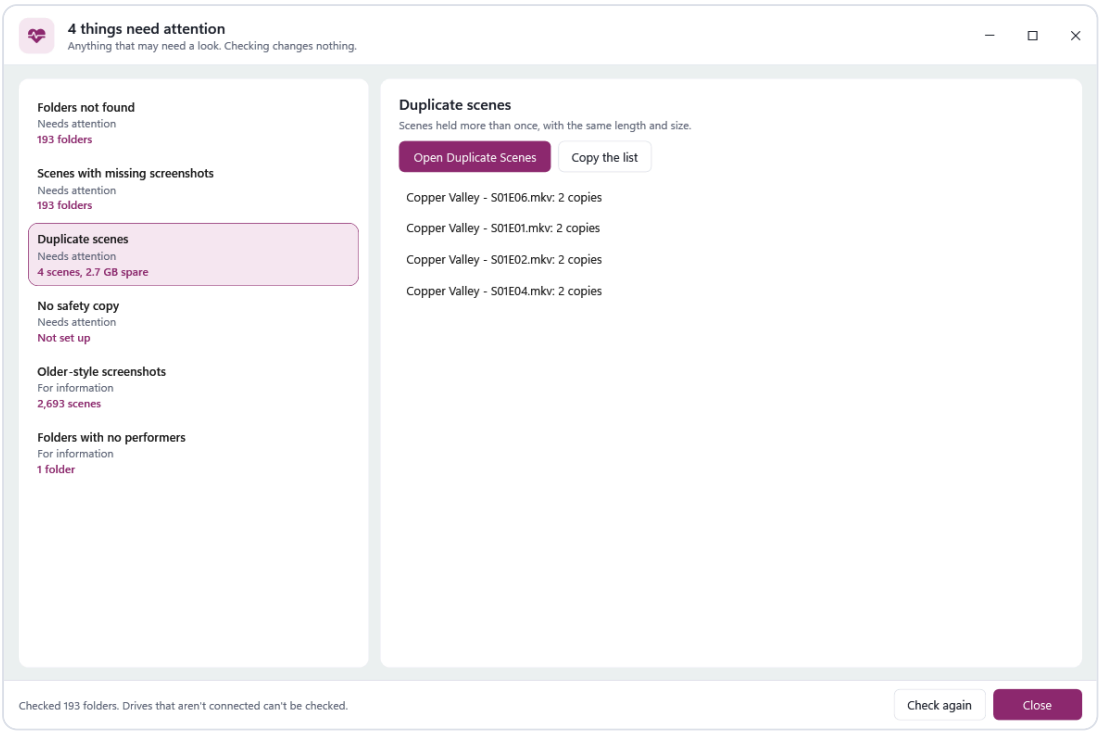
- A **quick check** reads the start and end of each video, about a second each. It finds files that won't open and files that were cut short.
- A **thorough check** reads every video right through, which takes about as long as copying them. It also finds damage in the middle.
- Files checked before and unchanged since are skipped. A file the check tagged corrupt has the tag taken off if it later passes.

Moving a folder to another drive

Right-click a folder and choose **Move to another drive...**. Pick the drive and the folder to put it in, then click **Move**. It checks there's room, copies the videos, checks each copy against its original, points the folder at the copy, and only then removes the originals, if you've asked it to. If anything goes wrong, or you stop it, the folder still points at the originals and the part-made copy is removed. The folder keeps its screenshots, cover, ratings and suggestions.

Collection Health

Collection > Collection Health... checks your whole collection and lists anything that may need attention. Checking changes nothing.



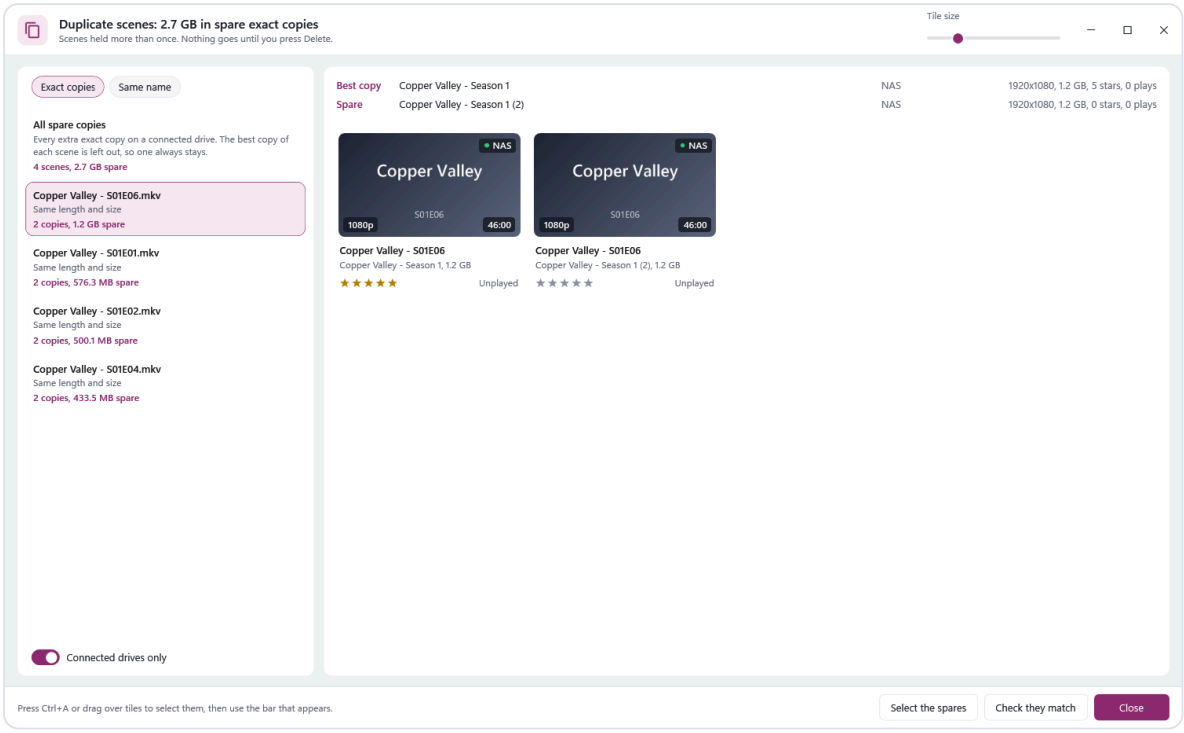
Collection Health

Choose a check on the left to see its details and, where it applies, a button that takes you to the fix.

Check	What it means
Problems from the last refresh	Files that couldn't be read, or screenshots that couldn't be taken
Folders not found	The drive is connected but the folder has moved
Missing screenshots	Refreshing the folder takes them again
Leftover screenshots	Screenshots of scenes no longer in your catalogue
Duplicate scenes	Scenes held more than once
Drives nearly full	Drives at 90% or more
Safety copy	Not set up, not found, or over 30 days old
Older-style screenshots	Scenes that Optimise Screenshots or Rebuild All Screenshots can bring up to date

Duplicate Scenes

Collection > Duplicate Scenes... finds scenes held more than once across your collection. The best copy of each is marked, going by rating, then plays or picture quality. Your Favourites folder is left out, as those copies are there on purpose.



Duplicate Scenes

Type	Meaning
Exact copies	The same length and the same size to the byte
Same name	The same name and length at different sizes, which is usually one scene encoded twice

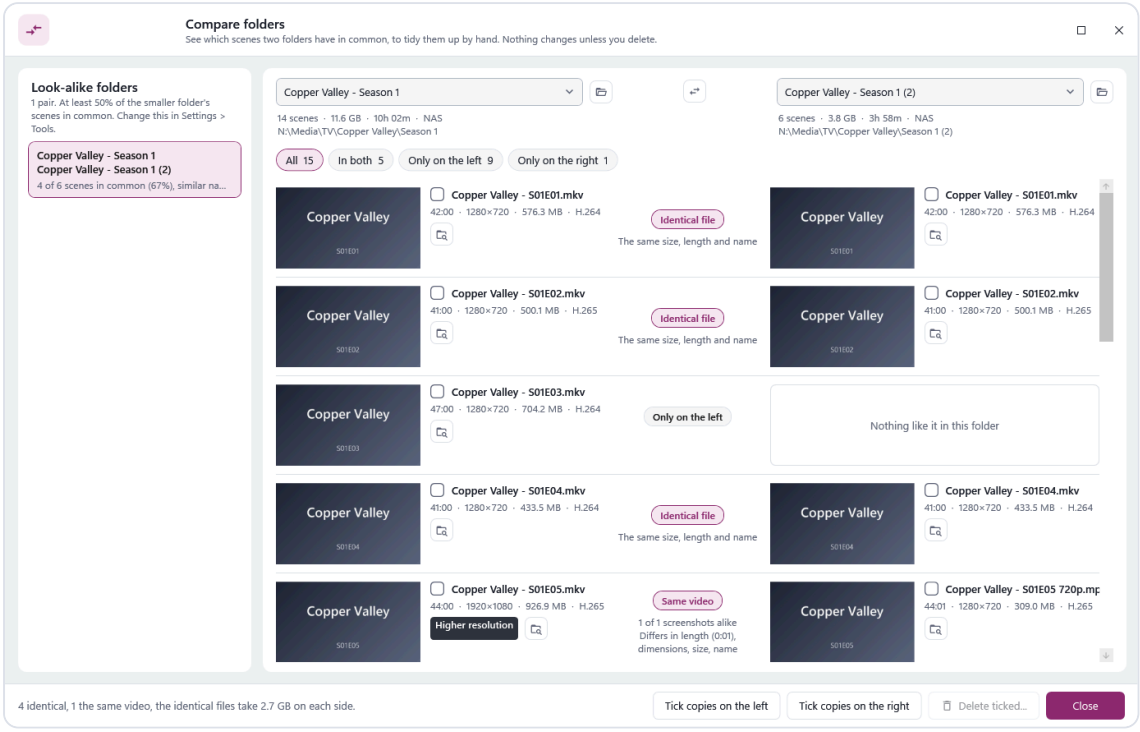
1. Choose a group on the left.
2. Click **Check they match** to compare samples from the files.
3. Click **Select the spares**, then use the bar that appears to delete them.

All spare copies lists every extra exact copy on your connected drives. The best copy of each scene is never included.

> **Check before deleting in bulk**
> Exact copies are matched from the catalogue, not by reading the files. Plays and tags on a deleted copy are lost, so start with a few groups.

Compare Folders

Sometimes the same videos end up in two folders, such as a season downloaded twice under different names. **Collection > Compare Folders...** shows two folders side by side, scene by scene, to help you tidy them up by hand. You can also right-click a folder and choose **Compare with...**, or pick two folders and click **Compare**.



Two copies of a season, compared

On the left are **look-alike folders**: pairs across your collection with enough scenes in common, the most in common first. Pick one to compare it. Each row pairs a scene with the one in the other folder it seems to be, going by the screenshots, names, lengths, sizes and dimensions:

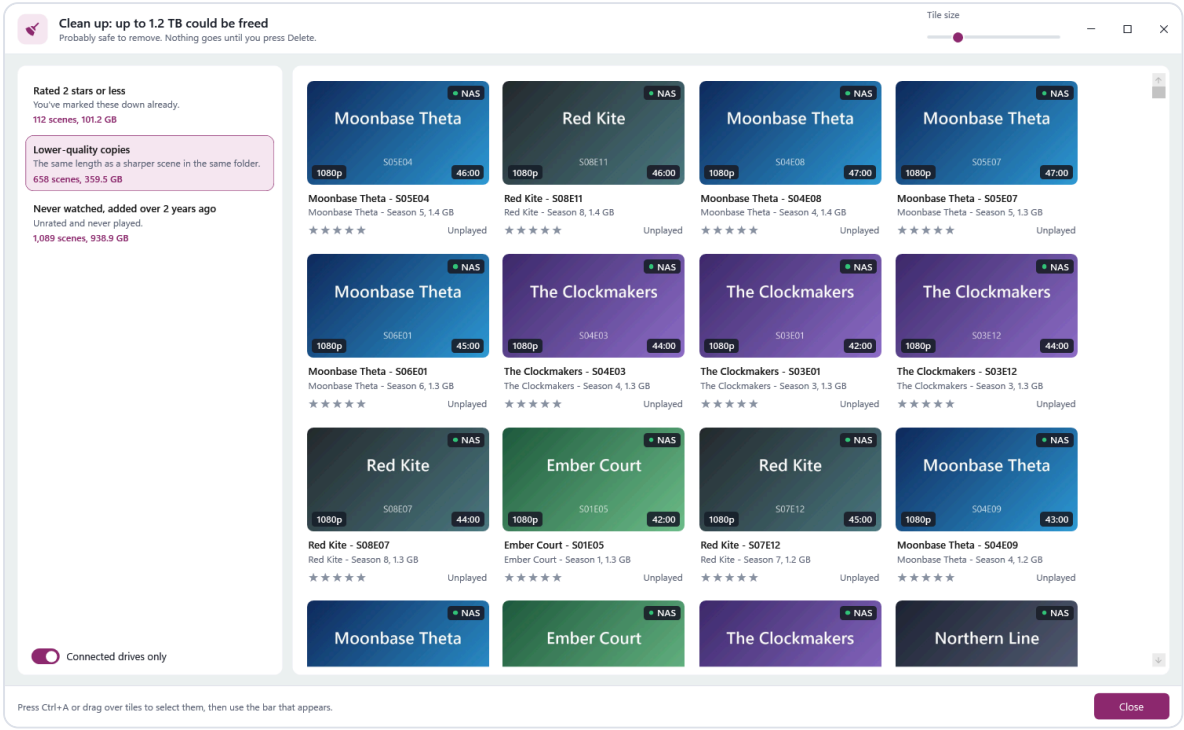
Verdict	Meaning
Identical file	The same size and length, even under another name
Same video	A close length and alike screenshots, such as a smaller copy. What differs is listed, and the better copy is marked
Maybe the same	The same name but a different length, or a similar name and length
Only on the left or **right**	Nothing like it in the other folder

Click a screenshot to play the scene, or the folder button to show it in File Explorer. Tick scenes to delete them, after asking, or use **Tick copies on the left** or **on the right** to tick the identical files on one side. Nothing else is changed: moving and merging are up to you. How much two folders must have in common to be listed is set in **Settings > Tools**.

Clean Up

Collection > Clean Up... suggests scenes you may want to remove, such as low ratings, lower-quality copies, very low resolution, old scenes you've never watched, and very short clips. Your 4 and 5-star scenes are never suggested.

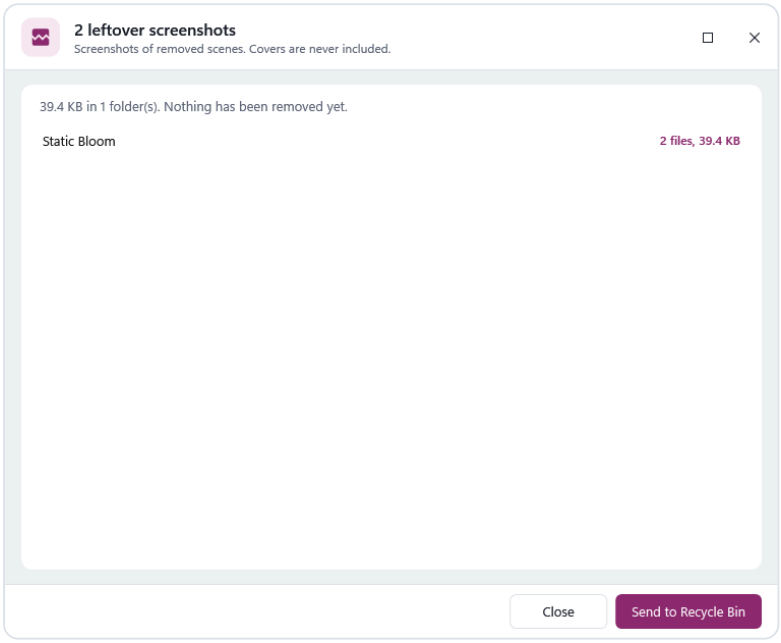
Choose a group, press **Ctrl+A** to pick its scenes, and use the bar that appears.



Clean Up

Screenshot tools

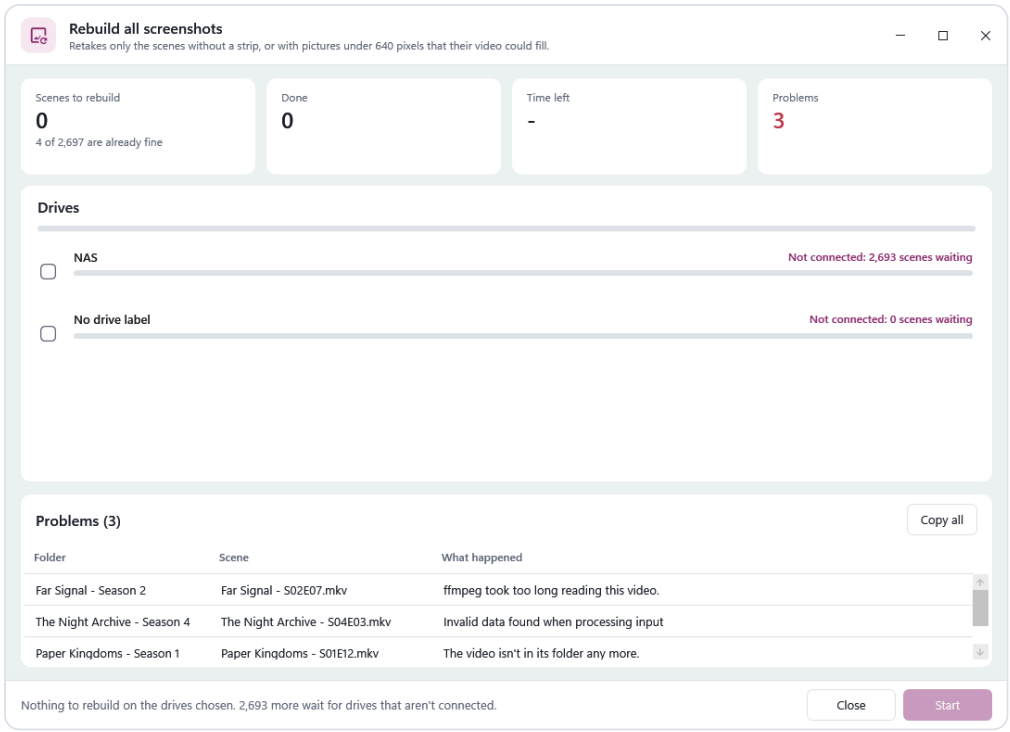
Tool	Use it to
Tools > Screenshot Leftovers...	Find screenshots of scenes that have gone, and send them to the Recycle Bin
Rebuild screenshots... (right-click a folder)	Take new screenshots for a folder. Its drive must be connected, and its cover is kept
Collection > Rebuild All Screenshots...	Check every scene and retake only those that need it. Choose which connected drives to process, and stop at any time: running it again carries on from there
Tools > Optimise Screenshots	Convert older scenes to the two-file format, using the screenshots they already have, so their drives don't need to be connected
Tools > Clean Up Old Backups...	Remove old automatic catalogue backups



Screenshot Leftovers

Rebuild All Screenshots shows progress for each drive, and lists anything that went wrong. Drag the gap between **Drives** and **Problems** to give the problems more room. The size is kept for next time.

With a cover model downloaded, each new screenshot is also scored for cover suggestions as the rebuild goes, so **Choose for me** opens straight away afterwards. The scoring runs one screenshot at a time alongside the rebuild, on the graphics card if that's switched on in **Settings > Covers**.



Rebuild All Screenshots, with three problems listed

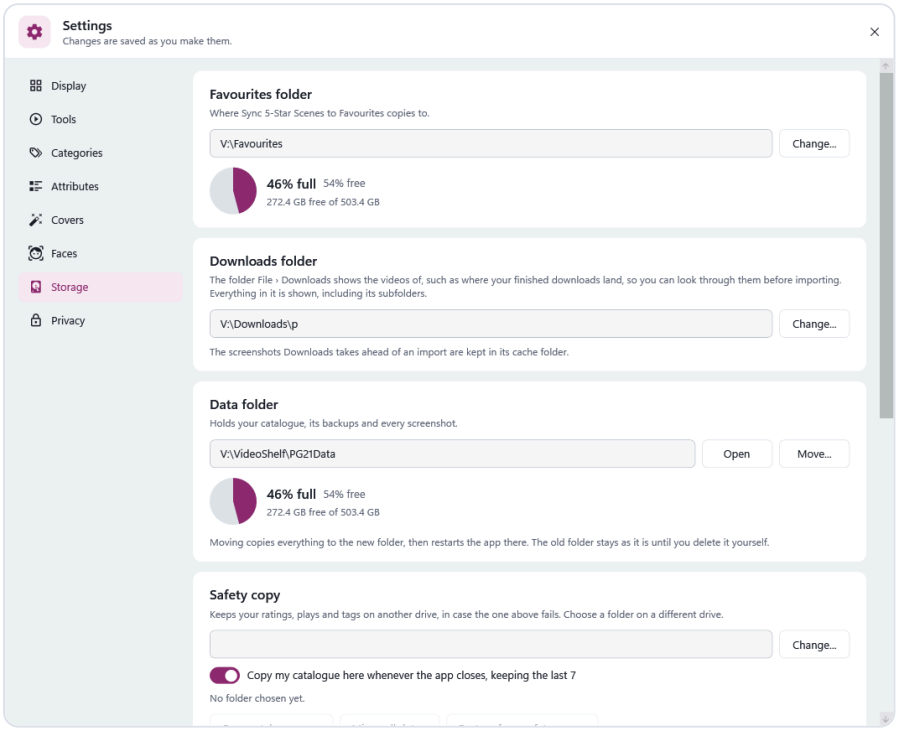
11. Keeping your data safe

Your videos are on your drives, but your ratings, plays and tags exist only in your catalogue. Keeping a copy of it is well worth a minute of setup.

Safety copy

Go to **Settings > Storage** and choose a folder on another drive. You can then:

- Copy the catalogue whenever the app closes, keeping the last seven copies.
- Copy it now.
- Mirror all your data, including screenshots. The first mirror can take a long time, and after that only changes are copied.



Settings: Storage

Clearing every scene tag

To start your scene tags again, use **Clear every scene tag...** at the bottom of **Settings > Storage**. It takes every tag off every scene in your collection. Folders' own tags, categories, attributes, ratings and plays are kept.

Because it can't be undone from the app, you're asked to type a phrase first, such as `walnut-cobalt-44`. It's different every time, so it can't be typed from habit, and it can't be pasted.

Your catalogue is copied to your data folder first, as `index-before-clearing-tags-` followed by the date and time. To bring the tags back, close Video Shelf, rename `index.db.gz` in your data folder to keep it, then copy that file and rename the copy to `index.db.gz`. Anything you changed after clearing is lost by doing so.

Moving your data

To keep your catalogue and screenshots on another drive, use **Move...** under **Data folder** in **Settings > Storage**. The app copies everything, then restarts using the new location. Your old folder isn't touched, so you can delete it once you're happy.

Restoring from your safety copy

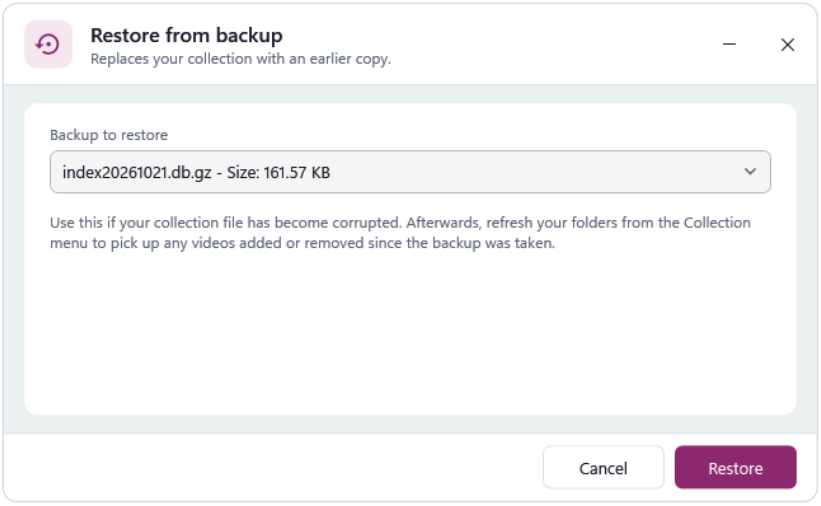
Click **Restore from safety copy...** in **Settings > Storage**, and choose a dated catalogue or your full mirror. A catalogue brings back your ratings, plays, tags and categories. The full mirror brings back everything, including screenshots, copying only what differs.

1. Close any other Video Shelf windows.
2. Choose what to restore, then click **Restore**. The copy is checked before anything changes.
3. Confirm. **Stop** leaves your catalogue as it was.
4. The app restarts. Refresh your folders to pick up anything added or removed since the copy was made.

> **Your current data is kept**
> What you had before is saved in a `before-restore` folder inside your data folder. If the copy had a PIN set, that PIN applies after restoring.

Restoring a backup

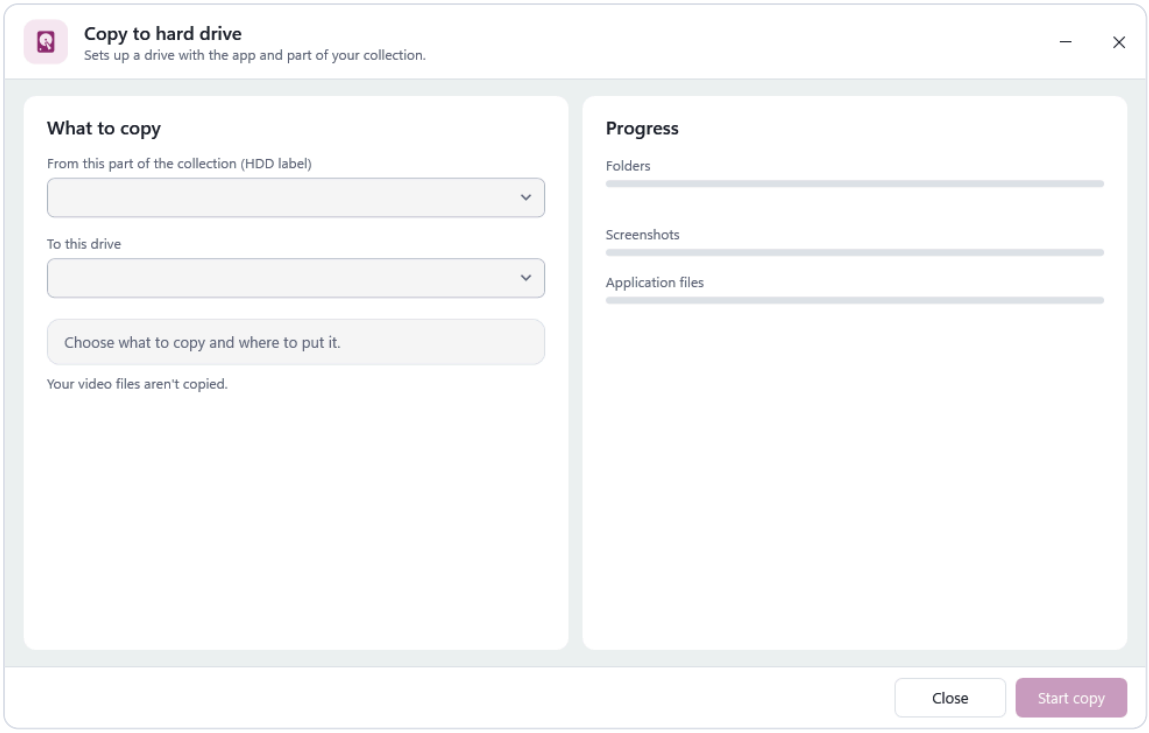
If your catalogue is ever empty or damaged when the app starts, it offers to list your recent backups from the data folder. Choose one, then refresh your folders to pick up anything added since.



Restoring from a backup

Copying to a hard drive

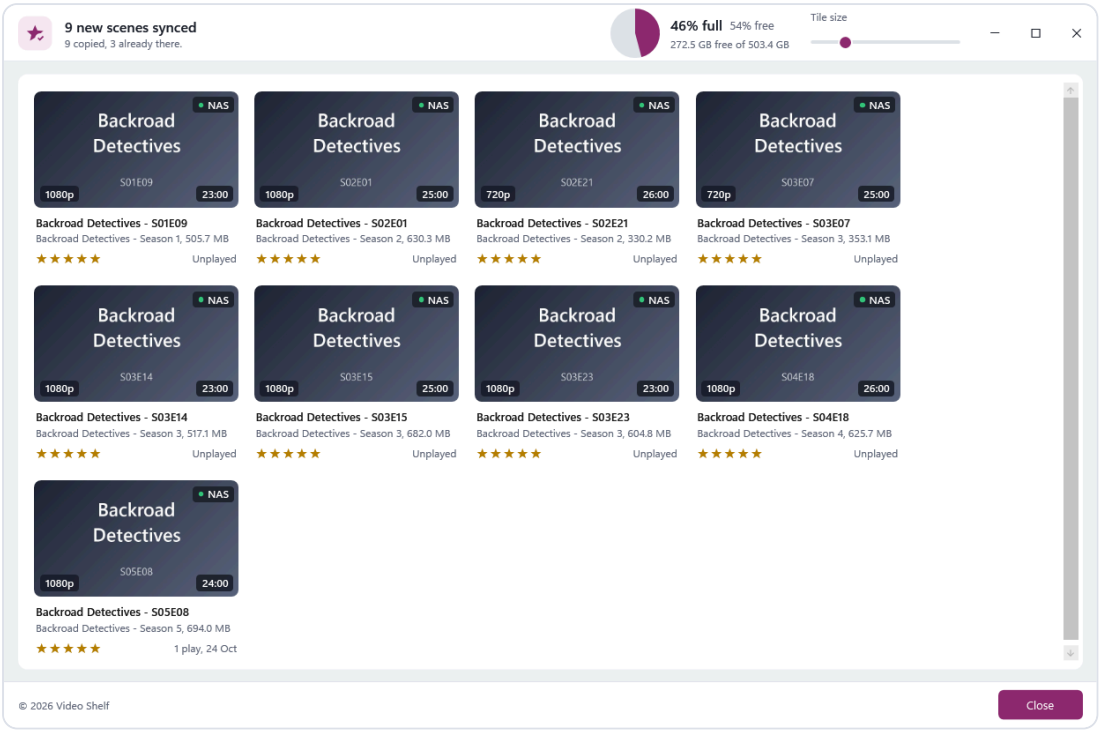
Tools > Initialise HDD Cache... sets up a drive with the app, plus the catalogue and screenshots for part of your collection. You can then browse that part on another PC, as a read-only copy. Your video files aren't copied.



Copy to Hard Drive

Favourites sync

Tools > Sync 5-Star Scenes to Favourites copies your 5-star scenes to one folder, for example on a portable drive. A card below the menus shows progress, speed, time left, and how much room is left on the drive. A results window then shows what was copied.

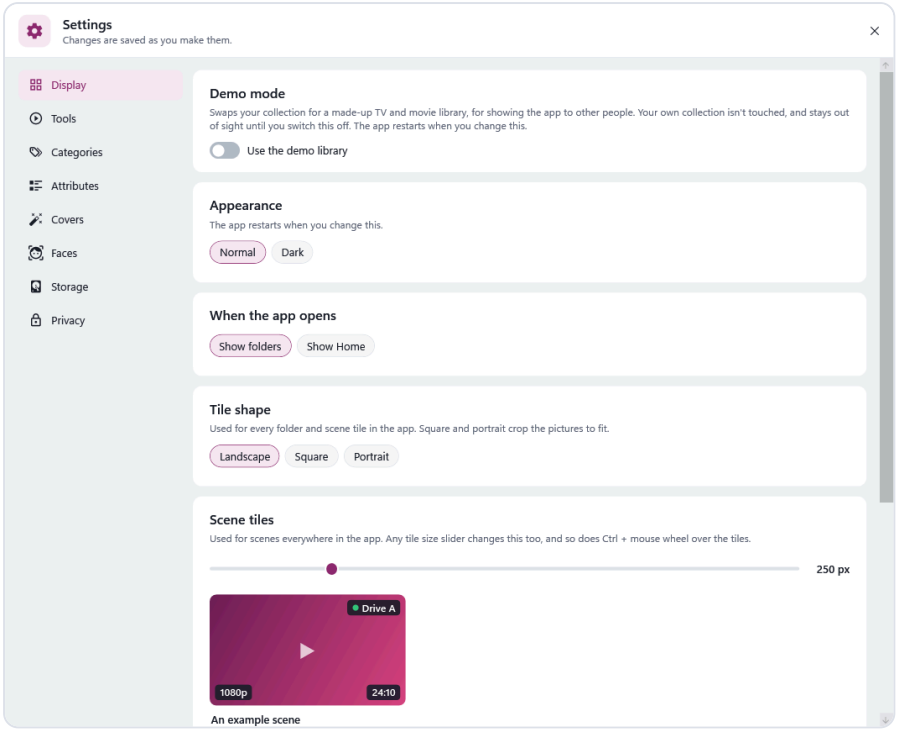


The results of a Favourites sync

12. Settings

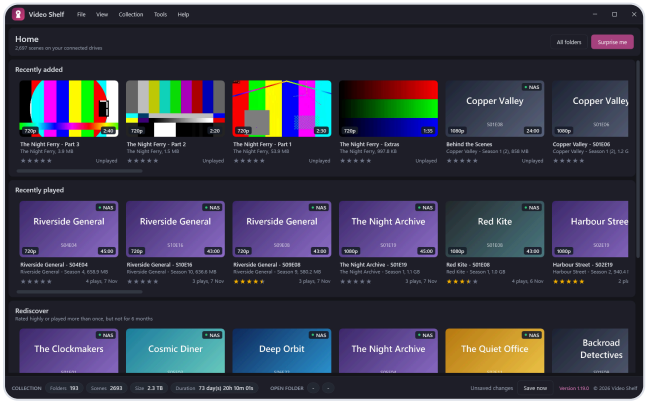
Open **File > Settings...**. Changes are saved as you make them.

Display

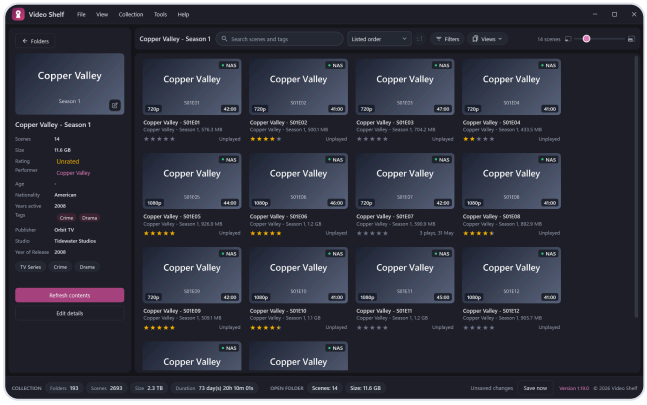


Settings: Display

Setting	What it does
Demo mode	Swaps your collection for a made-up film and TV library, for showing the app to other people. Your own collection stays out of sight, a **Demo** label shows in the title bar, and the app restarts
Appearance	Chooses Normal or Dark. The app restarts
When the app opens	Starts on your folders or on Home
Tile shape	Landscape, Square or Portrait, across the whole app
Scene tiles and **Folder tiles**	Set the size of each, with a preview

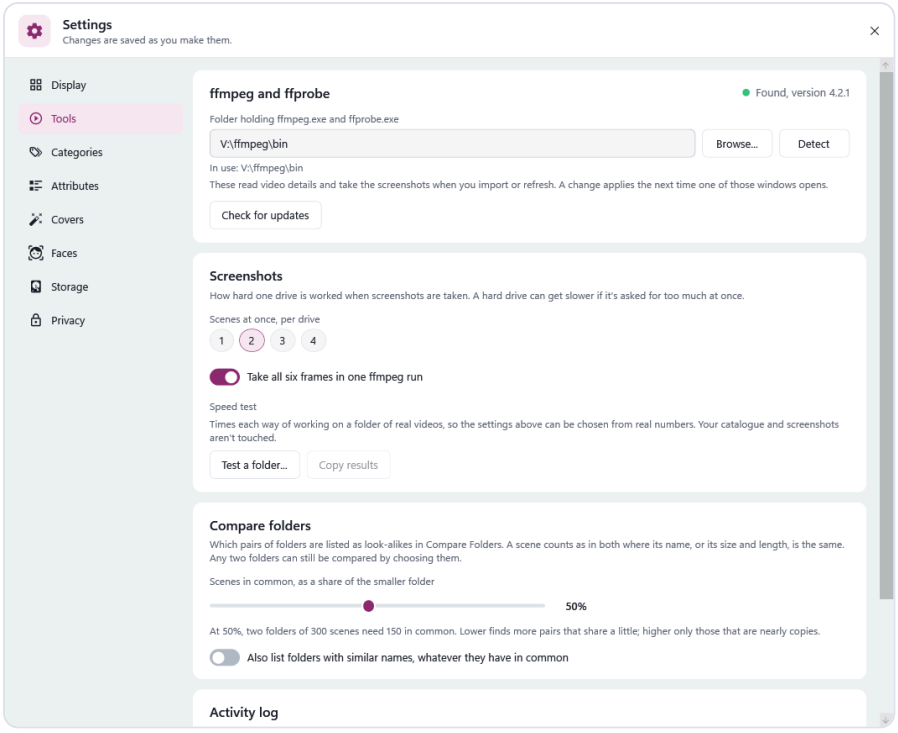


Home in Dark appearance



Scenes in Dark appearance

Tools

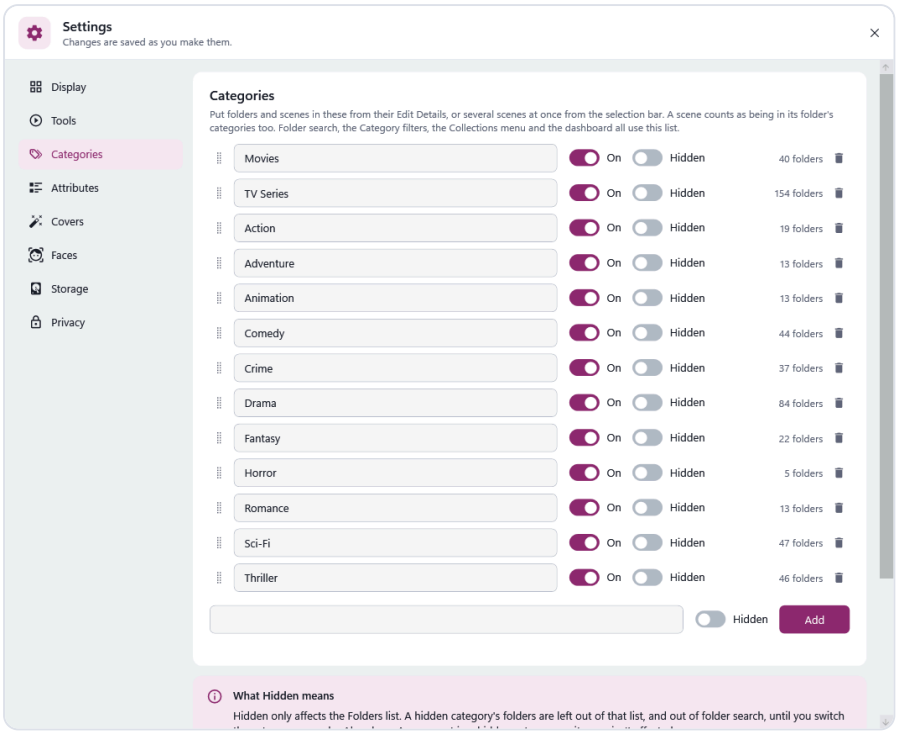


Settings: Tools

- **ffmpeg and ffprobe** read your videos and take screenshots. They aren't included with the app: see chapter 2. **Check for updates** tells you if there's a newer version and can open its download page. It never downloads anything itself. To use a new version, unpack it and click **Browse...** to choose its `bin` folder.
- **Screenshots** sets how many scenes each drive works on at once. **Test a folder...** times the options on your own videos, so you can pick the fastest for your drives.
- **Compare folders** sets how much two folders must have in common to be listed as look-alikes: by default, half the scenes of the smaller folder. A switch also lists folders with similar names, whatever they share, which finds copies saved under other file names.
- **Activity log** sets how much is written down. See chapter 13.

Categories

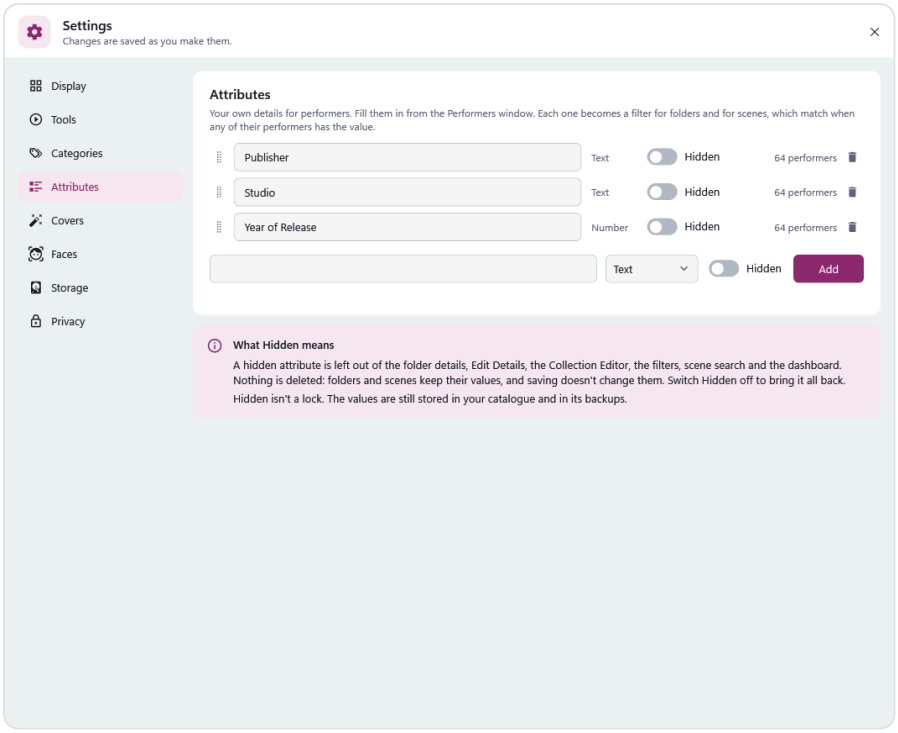
Add, reorder and remove categories, and choose whether each one is on, off or Hidden. If you delete a category that's in use, the app warns you first, then removes it from those folders.



Settings: Categories

Attributes

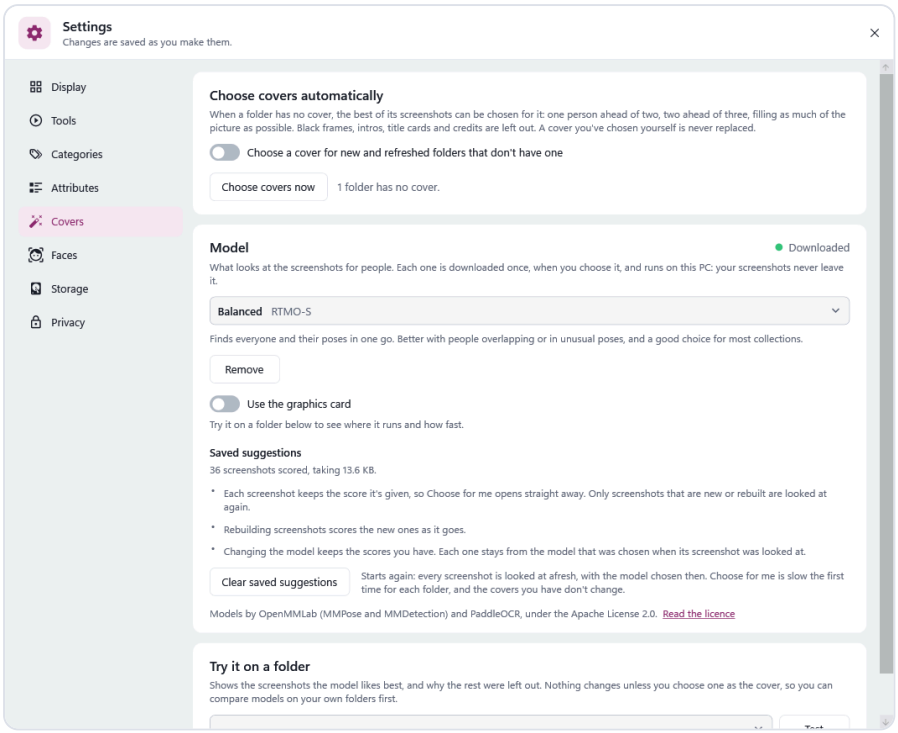
Add details of your own to keep on folders and scenes, such as Studio, Publisher or Year of Release, as text, a number or a date. Drag them into the order you want. **Hidden** takes an attribute out of view without changing the values held, and the count beside each one shows how many folders use it.



Settings: Attributes

Covers

The cover model looks at a folder's screenshots for people, to suggest a cover. It's downloaded once, when you choose it, and runs on your PC: your screenshots never leave it.

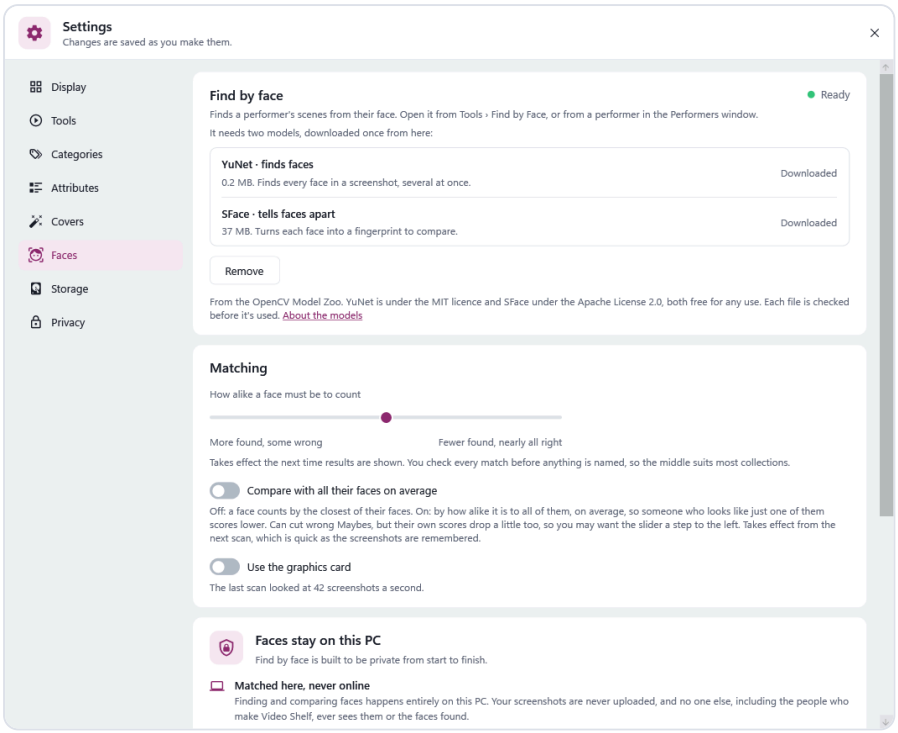


Settings: Covers

Setting	What it does
Choose a cover for new and refreshed folders	Gives any folder without a cover the best match among its screenshots, after an import or refresh. A cover you've chosen yourself is never replaced
Choose covers now	Does the same for every folder that has no cover
Model	Fast, Balanced or Most accurate. **Download** fetches it, and **Remove** deletes it again
Use the graphics card	Runs the model on the graphics card where it can, taking work off the processor
Try it on a folder	Shows the screenshots the model likes best, and why the rest were left out. Nothing changes unless you choose one

Faces

The two models Find by face needs, from the OpenCV Model Zoo: YuNet finds faces and SFace tells them apart. They're downloaded once from here, checked before use, and run on your PC.



Settings: Faces

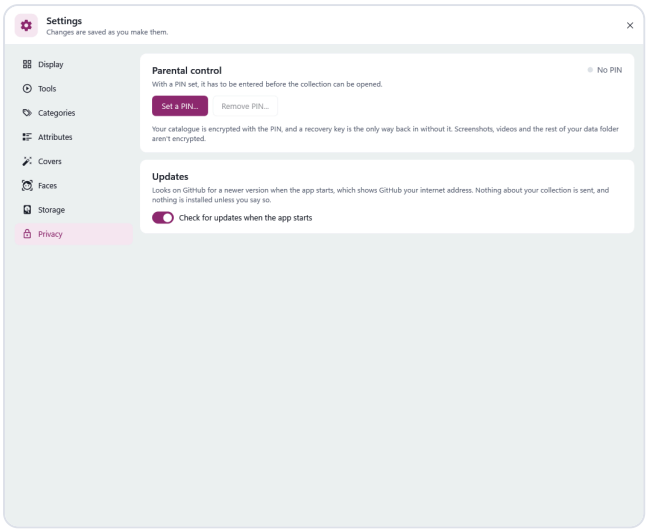
Setting	What it does
Download / Remove	Fetches the two models (38 MB), or deletes them again. The faces already found are kept
How alike a face must be to count	Towards the left finds more, with some wrong; towards the right finds fewer, nearly all right, and fewer Maybes. It changes how results are sorted into Likely and Maybe the next time they're shown. Scanning again is quick, as the screenshots are remembered. You check every match before anything is named
Compare with all their faces on average	Off, as it starts: a face found counts by the closest of their faces. On: by how alike it is to all of them, on average, so someone who looks like just one of their faces scores lower. It can cut wrong Maybes, but their own scores drop a little too, so you may want the slider above a step to the left. It takes effect from the next scan. Try a scan each way and keep whichever suits your collection
Use the graphics card	Runs the models on the graphics card where it can. They're small, so the processor is often just as quick
Delete all face data	Deletes every face found and every face picked, for everyone. Your videos, screenshots and catalogue aren't touched

Storage

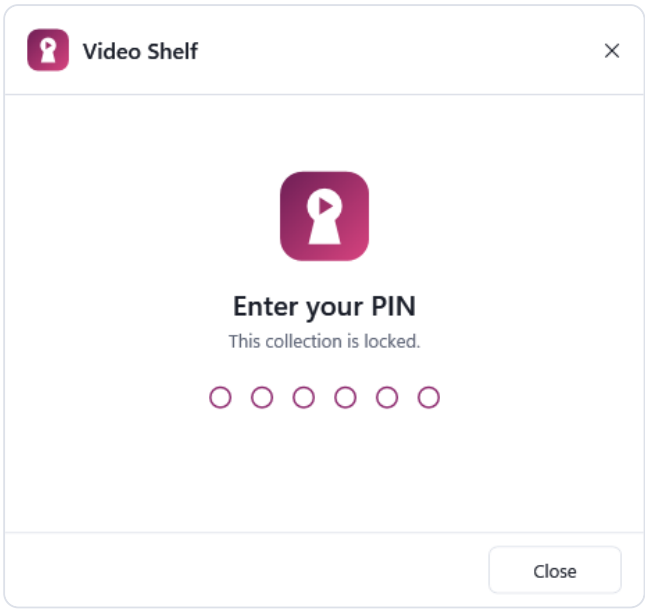
Your Favourites folder, your data folder and your safety copy. See chapter 11.

Privacy

Set a six-digit PIN to lock the app when it starts. Nothing in your collection is shown until the PIN is entered. Switching a category back on also needs the PIN.



Settings: Privacy



The PIN screen at start-up

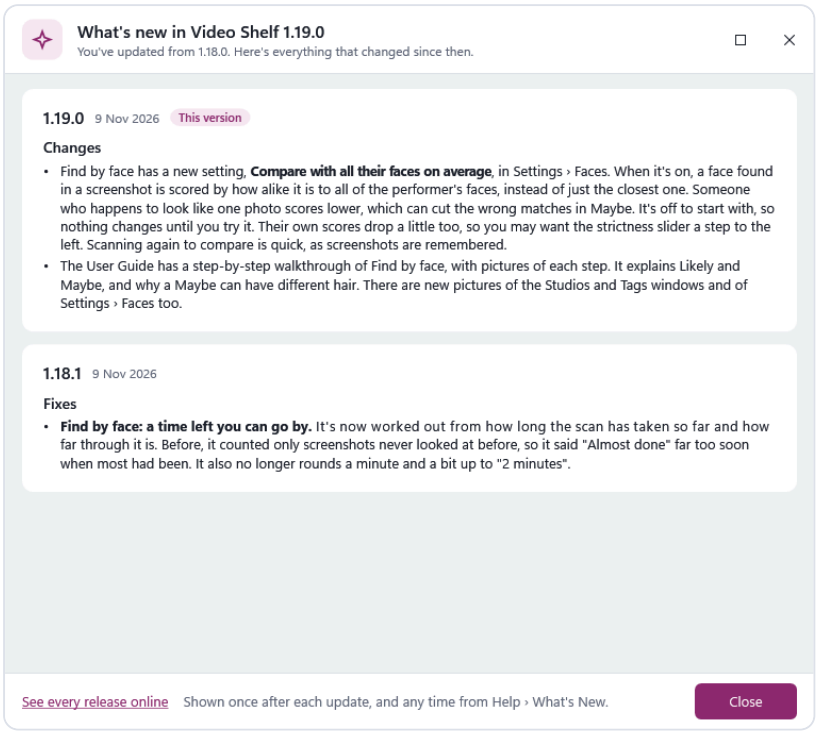
> **Keep your recovery key safe**
> Setting a PIN encrypts your catalogue, and you're shown a recovery key once. If you forget your PIN, click **Forgotten it?** and enter that key. Without either one, the catalogue can't be opened. Screenshots and the rest of your data folder aren't encrypted.

To stop the app looking for updates when it starts, switch off **Check for updates when the app starts**. The check shows GitHub your internet address, and nothing about your collection is sent.

13. Help and reference

What's New

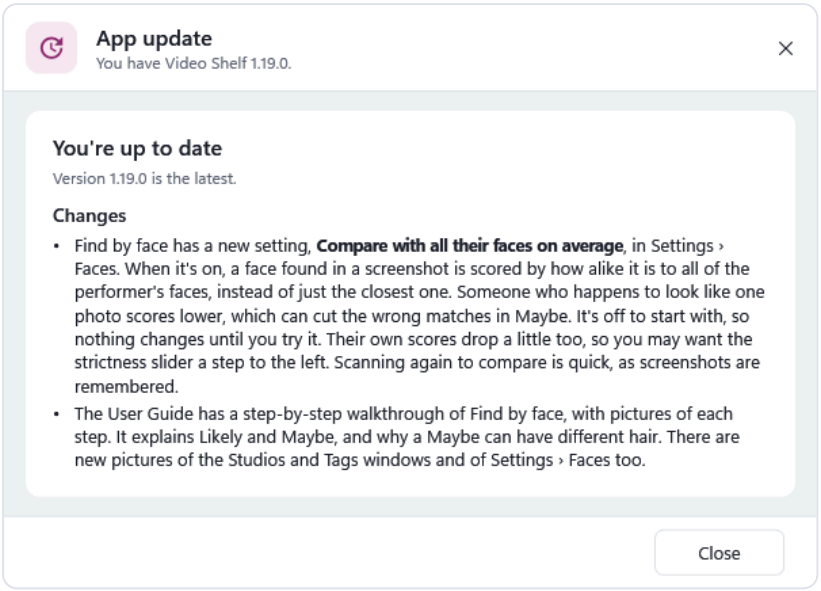
After an update, a window shows what changed in every version since the one you had, so nothing is missed if you skip one. **Help > What's New...**, or the version in the status bar, shows the latest changes at any time. The notes come from the release pages online, so they need an internet connection.



What's New

Updates

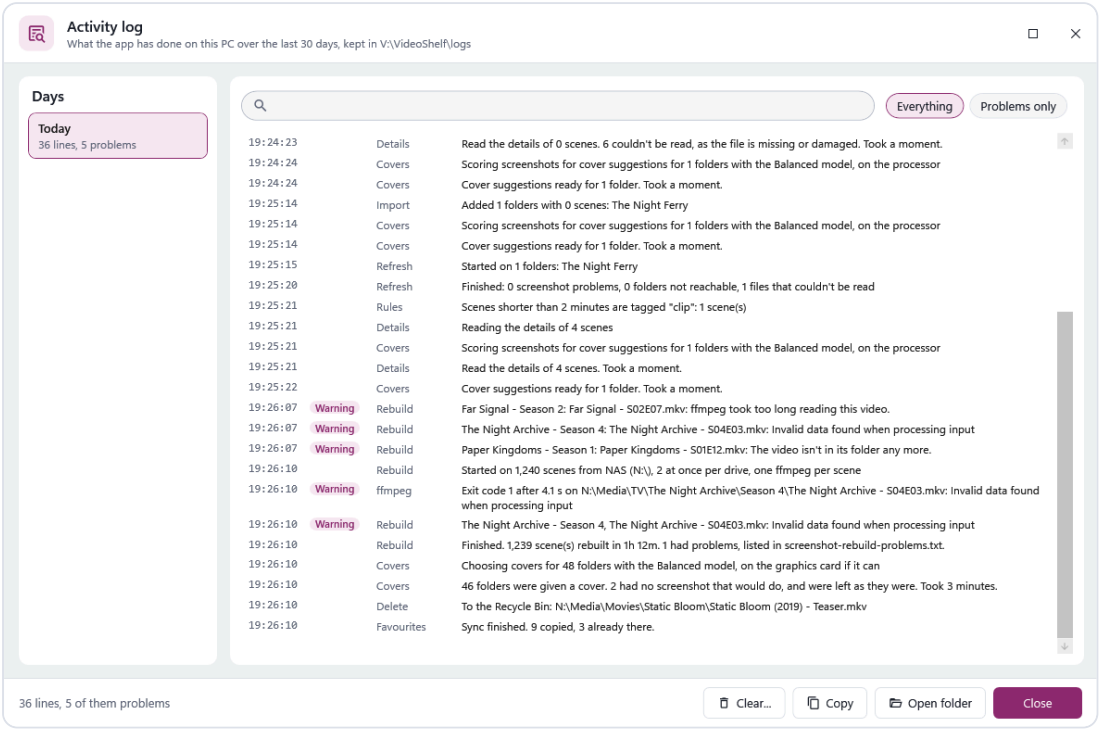
When a new version is published, a button in the status bar offers it. **Help > Check for Updates...** looks straight away. Choose **Download and install** and the app downloads the update, checks it, closes and runs the installer. Your collection isn't touched, and nothing is installed unless you ask.



Checking for updates

The activity log

Help > Activity Log... shows what the app has done on this PC over the last 30 days: rebuilds, refreshes, imports, covers, trims, updates, every file deleted, and anything that went wrong, such as a video ffmpeg couldn't read. Choose a day on the left, search it, or show **Problems only**. **Copy** copies the lines you've picked, **Open folder** shows the log files, and **Clear...** deletes a day or the whole log.



The activity log

If the app or the PC stops without closing properly, the next start notes what the app was last doing, and what Windows recorded about the restart. That helps tell an app problem from a PC one.

Settings > Tools > Activity log sets how much is written down:

Level	What's written
Detailed	Everything, including each scene of a screenshot rebuild. Best for finding out why something went wrong
Normal	What the app did and anything that went wrong, but not each step of a long job. This is where it starts
Problems only	Only what went wrong
Off	Nothing

> **Before you share a log**
> The log names the files the app worked on, with their folders. Bear that in mind if you send it to anyone.

Keyboard and mouse

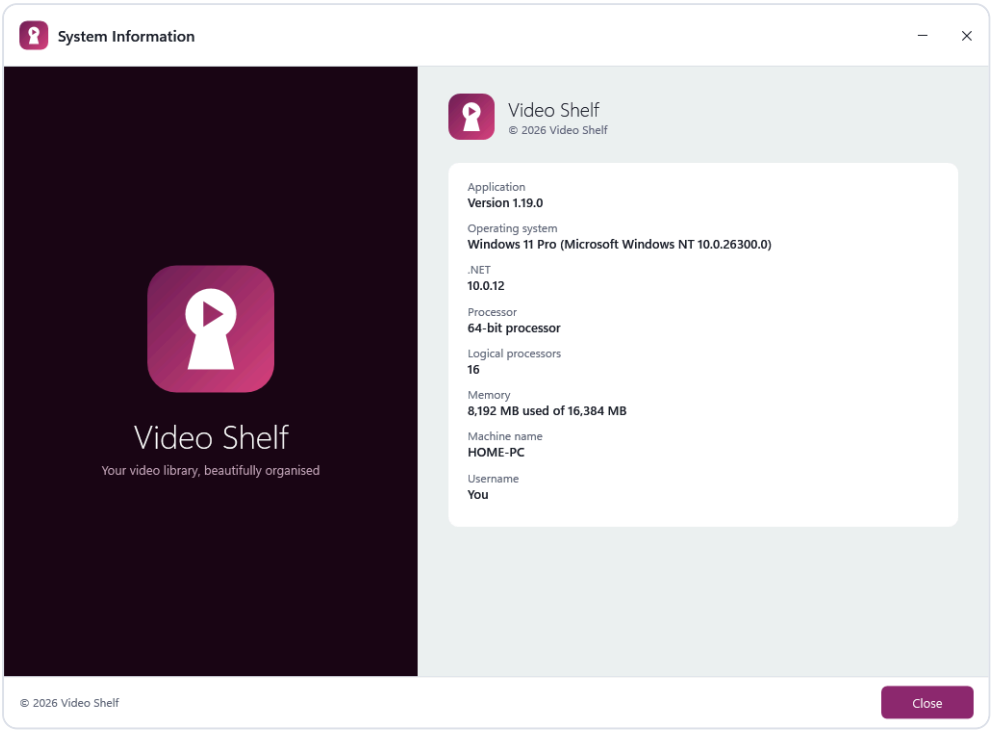
Keys	Action
Ctrl+F	Go to the search box
Ctrl+Shift+F	Open or close the filters
Ctrl + mouse wheel	Change the tile size
Ctrl+A	Pick all the scenes or folders shown, or none if they all are
Escape	Clear what's picked
Ctrl + click, **Shift** + click	Add to what's picked, or pick a run
Drag over tiles	Pick an area
Delete	Delete the picked scenes, after asking
Enter	Open the chosen folder, or play the chosen scene
Esc	Close the filters, clear what's picked, or clear a search

Troubleshooting

What you see	What to do
A folder's tiles are dimmed	Its drive isn't connected. Connect it and the folder is available again
"This scene's file can't be found"	Check the drive is connected, then refresh the folder in case the file moved
A file "couldn't be read"	The video may be damaged. Try playing it. It's skipped until a later refresh can read it
Screenshots are missing	Refresh the folder. If the problem stays, see **Collection Health** for the reason, or try a newer ffmpeg
Screenshots take a long time	Try the speed test in **Settings > Tools**
No cover is suggested	Download a model in **Settings > Covers**. If none of a folder's screenshots suits, choose one yourself, or rebuild its screenshots and look again
Too many, or too few, look-alike folders	Change how much they must have in common in **Settings > Tools**
The app or PC stopped part way through a job	Open **Help > Activity Log**. The next start notes what was happening. Set the log to **Detailed** to see each step next time
"Close the other windows first"	Close any other Video Shelf windows, then try again
The drive is full during a sync	The sync copies as many scenes as there's room for, in order

System Information

Help > User Guide opens this guide. **Help > System Information...** shows details of the app and your PC, which are useful if you ever need support. **Help > About...** shows the version and the size of your collection.



System Information